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# 1 The Position

John O. Evjen

## 1.1 Installment 1: “Folkebladet” March 13, 1918

For several years certain disagreements have made themselves felt in Folkebladet concerning the Free Church’s Guiding Principles, regarding what they mean and what consequences they entail. There has been much discussion about it.

The discussion does not seem likely to cease. It is almost as if the Free Church has a broken arm that must be set. The sufferer’s thoughts remain on the broken arm until it is healed. Since the understandings of the principles are exceedingly different, frictions arise. They may often look worse than they are, and those involved in the frictions may sometimes be subjected to harsh judgments. These judgments can sound quite peculiar, for example like the one a little schoolboy wrote in a composition about a horse: “The horse is a very fierce animal. If you attack him he will kick you.” So it can happen that men such as Birkeland and myself may be thought both brute beasts and ‘fierce’.

But, as has been said, so long as the arm is in pain, the thoughts remain fixed on it. And so it is with the principles. It is possible that they mean more than an arm on the Free Church’s body; it is possible that they mean less. At any rate, they play an exceedingly important role in determining the right to vote at the Free Church’s annual meetings. And surely the meaning is that the principles are to be respected between the annual meetings as well. But so long as there prevails lack of clarity with respect to their meaning and their consequences, it is natural that there should be discussion about them.

More recently, the discussion has centered most sharply on the question: Is Folkebladet against Augsburg? In other words, does the present editorial board of Folkebladet interpret the understanding of the congregation maintained in the Guiding Principles, which were in fact essentially drafted by Sverdrup and Oftedal, who were the leading voices both at Augsburg and in Folkebladet?

From the very beginning of his work in America, Folkebladet’s founder,<sup>1</sup> Prof. Oftedal upheld the concept of the church advanced in the Guiding Principles, while Sverdrup, it seems, did not fully come over to his side until after 1876. They were always agreed about ecclesiastical freedom. But in the first years at Augsburg Sverdrup taught, as we still so often find among Lutheran theologians, that the congregation began at Christ’s ascension, not first at the

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<sup>1</sup>Oftedal founded Folkebladet in FIXME.

outpouring of the Spirit. In this connection he could say that it was the “first congregation” that chose an apostle to take Judas’s office, whereas later he always taught that the choice of this apostle was not a congregational election, since the congregation was first born at the outpouring of the Spirit. Likewise, he taught that a local congregation, a church body, a branch of the church, is a member of Christ’s body, a stone in God’s temple. “Christ is the head of all, and every congregation is a member of His body, a living stone in the new temple of God.” A church body is “an independent member of the body.” “The Church as a whole is Christ’s body.” (Collected Writings I.)<sup>2</sup>

After 1876, and right up to his death, Sverdrup taught, like Oftedal, that the local congregation—that is, the believers within it—is not a stone in the temple, nor a member of Christ’s body, but is itself the temple, God’s house, Christ’s body. The other ecclesiastical organizations he regarded as historical arrangements, not divinely instituted in the way the local congregation is, though useful organs for the congregation. Both Sverdrup and Oftedal were, until the 1890s, advocates of church association in the sense that they desired an association of congregations; but they were not church-body men in the sense that the church body or synod was anything more than an outward expedient.

In faculty opinions, treatises, and in part also sermons, the theological professors at Augsburg again and again set forth that the congregation (the local congregation) is the “only outward form of the Church” (the Church—the holy catholic Church; compare question 243 in the Free Church’s edition of Pontoppidan’s Explanation): “the proper divine order within the Christian religion”; “the truly proper form of Christianity’s manifestation in the world”; “the proper form of God’s kingdom on earth”; the only outward form of His kingdom on earth appointed by God; “the foundational truth of the Church is and remains according to God’s Word the congregation alone and no church body”; “according to Scripture the congregation is the highest form of association”; “the outward form of the kingdom of God, which is the congregation.” Prof. Oftedal wrote in the 1870s that Elling Eielsen abolished the visible Church in order to set the invisible Church, the communion of saints, in its place. In Eielsen’s understanding he found “no room for the only outward form of the Church that God’s Word mentions, namely the congregation.” In a long joint declaration from the 1870s it was stated that the church body “has no such divine right as the congregation, but, like all outward church bodies, has arisen through historical development”; likewise that “it belongs inseparably to the essence of the Christian Church to exist in the form of congregations.”

That it is local congregations everywhere that are meant here is self-evident. But this

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<sup>2</sup>Professor Georg Sverdrup *Biblical and Church-Historical Sketches and Addresses* Edited by Andreas Helland 1909)

will, moreover, also appear from many other citations in this article. The congregation is everywhere presented as the proper form, set by God, for the holy catholic Church, the Church, or the kingdom, in contrast to the state-church form, the church-body form, the papal-church form, and the ‘free-free’ form. For the time being, it will suffice to refer to the treatise “What Is the Congregation” in *Collected Writings II*, p. 12, where we read this:

Our children’s catechism teaches what the Church is, but not directly of what the congregation is. The New Testament, however, speaks all the more of the congregation or the congregations. Now people sometimes call them local congregations, or ‘local churches.’ It is by no means free from a certain tinge of disparagement when people speak of ‘local congregations.’ We therefore take the liberty of observing that what is spoken of here is the ‘local congregation.’ And since it is an indisputable fact that the New Testament speaks with the deepest reverence and utmost holy seriousness precisely of the local congregations, and calls them God’s congregations and God’s temple and Christ’s body and Christ’s bride, it is not too much if we also, with all reverence and respect, speak of this divine institution among us and esteem it very highly for Christ’s and God’s sake.

Let it be noted that the local congregation is designated a ‘divine institution.’

Sverdrup considered it a deficiency in the children’s catechism that it did not speak directly of what the congregation was. For this reason he altered question 243<sup>3</sup> in the Explanation, and wrote: “Is the holy catholic Church found here among us?” His answer reads: “Yes, in the congregation, which in Scripture is called Jesus Christ’s body and God’s house.” The next question, concerning the outward congregation, might lead one to think that the word “congregation” in the answer to question 243 means all believers on earth. But that would be a hasty conclusion, which cannot be defended in the light of all that both Sverdrup and Oftedal wrote about “congregation” and “outward congregation.”

Thus the congregation is the proper form. It is governed by the law of Christ’s body.

Church bodies, state churches, and free churches (associations of congregations) are not governed by the law of Christ’s body (*Guidance II*, 33, 145).<sup>4</sup> We may use an analogy: the congregation is the proper form of the kingdom of God, somewhat as monogamy is the highest form of union between man and woman, in contrast to polygamy. This is admittedly a very imperfect comparison; it limps, as all figures do, especially if one were to regard the other forms of the kingdom as somehow immoral. But the point is plain enough.

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<sup>3</sup>FIXME to point to question 243

<sup>4</sup>FIXME point to *Guidance II*, 33, 145

This understanding of the congregation as the “proper form” and Christ’s body is, so far as Lutherans are concerned, distinctive of the Free Church (and we may add the free-church people in Norway, for example Odland, Jens Greve, and Solem; but not The Evangelical Lutheran Free Church). Otherwise I know of no other Lutheran church body in the world that maintains this understanding. All other Lutheran church bodies maintain that “Christ’s body,” when applied to the concept of the Church, has reference to the holy catholic Church, which consists of all believers on earth, but has no reference to any local congregation. In other words, “Christ’s body” must be applied to the whole organism, not to any organization.

In this respect, the Free Church stands almost alone among Lutherans. It is true that a couple of editors in the new church body, The Norwegian Lutheran Church body, have stated that this church body also teaches that the congregation is the “proper form.” But their statements show that they have not penetrated deeply enough into the Free Church understanding of the congregation. And one cannot hold that against them, seeing that so many of our own people do not have one and the same understanding of principle no. 1 in our “Guiding Principles.” Besides, they are contradicted by Pastor Langjærd in “The Lutheranism of Our Four-Hundred-Year Lutheranism.”

But if this principle is peculiar to the Free Church as a Lutheran ‘body,’ then it shares that principle with Congregationalists and Baptists. It may indeed offend many to hear that we are in such company. But a fact is not abolished by offense. Nor does it make Sverdrup and Oftedal dependent on the Reformed, any more than The Open Declaration—simply because it accused the Synod of Catholicism—made Synod people into Catholics, so it does not make Sverdrup and Oftedal dependent upon the Reformed, although Sverdrup already in 1876 thought that we could learn from “such a congregational church as the Reformed has long been,” and that “it would be sheer self-conceit to think that there was nothing to learn from those who have tried these things before us” (the Reformed in America). *Collected Writings* I, 143.

One cannot expect the ordinary man, nor even the pastor strongly occupied in practical work, to be able to find time and occasion to acquaint himself very much with the Lutheran and Reformed literature on church polity. But it is fair to expect of one who writes publicly about the Guiding Principles and criticizes others’ understanding of them, that he acquaint himself with them well enough to know what the principles mean, what is consistent with them, and how much they have in common with Luther and how much or how little they have in common with Calvin. One does not gain much insight into the ‘Guiding Principles’ by reading dogmatics, for dogmatics treats the congregation as an object of faith. But one finds light in the literature on church polity and in church history.

But do we not already have all the teaching we need? Have we not sat at the feet of the “older teachers”?

Yes—but how much did we hear there about the “Guiding Principles” and the Augsburg understanding of the congregation? From Oftedal, almost nothing; from Sverdrup, a few lectures, given every third year when he came to the end of Lønning’s dogmatics, which he mercilessly tore to pieces.

But what we did not hear, we did get to read in the papers. Several of us have read Sverdrup’s and Oftedal’s articles again and again, and in context. Here at Augsburg almost everything that Sverdrup and Oftedal wrote is accessible; and almost all the books they used as professors (including the marginal notes they made) are accessible. As far as possible I have tried to acquaint myself with their work as teachers and public writers, so that I dare say that I have a fairly well-grounded knowledge of their ecclesiastical views.

I hope that no one will take this as though it were spoken in a proud spirit. I am well aware of my limitations. As for me, I did not gallop through Augsburg, as many others did. And when I was finished with Augsburg I had to continue my schooling for three to four years before I could, with a reasonably good scholarly conscience—if one may use that expression, present myself as a candidate for a pastoral call or a teaching post. And finally, after several years of teaching at other schools, I had thus come to know Augsburg both at close hand and from afar, and now once again I came to know it more intimately than ever before. (To be continued.)

## 1.2 Installment 2: “Folkebladet,” March 20, 1918

When I took up Sverdrup’s Collected Writings, the principles, and so forth, I studied them without any preconceived opinion. I studied them in the light of the experiences I had had, and the knowledge I had gathered.

When I read the second volume of the Collected Writings, the volume that bears the title *The Congregation*, I had to say: this volume has for the most part to do with church polity.

What a spiritually dead conclusion! I hear someone say. Can Eyen not see that the volume *The Congregation* deals directly with awakening and life?

But no, I classified the book under ecclesiastical literature on church polity. Nor was I the only one who did so. Pastor S. E. Sjørgensen,<sup>5</sup> of Trondhjem, Norway, did the same, when in 1910 he wrote:

“The second volume consists almost exclusively of articles from the long debate over questions of church polity that has been carried on among our countrymen in America.”

And he added: “The rich and mighty Reformed church life pulsating all around him (Sverdrup) would seem to have been able to furnish him with more than enough analogies, at any rate. But it is remarkable how small a role all this plays, if indeed it can be said to be touched upon at all.”

Thus, Sjørgensen held that the second volume of Sverdrup’s Collected Writings was directed toward church polity, and that the Reformed church life could have furnished Sverdrup with more than enough analogies. Unfortunately, however, we were told by our pastors that there had never been any discussion of church polity among the Norwegian Lutherans in America! Reflections force themselves upon one.

Was Sjørgensen mistaken? Was it lack of spirit, of experience, of theological formation, that caused him to write thus?

I do not think so. I believe he could hold his own with any of us in these matters. As a

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<sup>5</sup>Pastor S. E. Sjørgensen, born in 1846, cand. theol. 1873, missionary pastor in the service of the Norwegian Missionary Society in Madagascar, where he directed the Norwegian Mission’s seminary, 1875–1886. Director of the Mission School in Stavanger, 1892–97. Later pastor in Trondheim. *Illustreret Norsk Konversations Leksikon* says: “S. has been one of the most prolific authors in the field of missionary literature. We mention here *Missionslære* [Theory of Missions], *Trold og Kirke paa Madagaskar* [Sorcery and the Church in Madagascar], *Vidnesbyrd fra Missionen* [Testimonies from the Mission], *Missionsprækener* [Mission Sermons], and many articles concerning church questions and missions in church periodicals and the daily press. In the Malagasy language he has written a larger church history, pastoral theology, liturgics, and several other commentaries.

competent theologian he gave the matter its right name.

Sørgensen spoke, as we see, of analogies. I have more than once called attention to these analogies in my lectures on church polity. And I hope this will not be regarded as some unpardonable offense.

What Sørgensen says of Volume II may, with greater or lesser reservation, also be said of Volumes III and IV.

By comparing Sverdrup's articles on the congregation with the polity literature that stands at my disposal, I find exceedingly little in Sverdrup for which I do not find analogies in my works on church polity, which fill a shelf six feet long. I speak perhaps speaking as a fool before the wise, but others do the same also, for example Harvard's five-foot shelf of classics. I do not at all mean to say that Sverdrup drew from this literature. But no one can deny the kinship: it is intimate.

Now there are doubtless those who would dismiss this six-foot shelf as a mere little list, and its contents as trivial stuff. But there is something strange about this content: it is counted trivial on that shelf, but becomes at once spirit and life when it comes between the covers of the Collected Writings. One wonders whether opponents are justified in drawing the distinction they have habitually drawn: polity versus spirit and life.

What is true of most of Sverdrup's and Oftedal's contributions to church debate holds especially for "Guiding Principles." All these principles — they are eight, in twelve paragraphs — are polity principles, neither more nor less.

Any recognized Protestant theological faculty in Scandinavia or Germany that is allowed to see the principles will be able to tell us that. That they are of significance for spirit and life, no one will deny. But one may say that about all work for the kingdom of God, yes, also about collections of money for seminary, mission, and so forth. Week after week the receipts lay claim to many columns in *Folkebladet*. It never comes to an end, yet no one complains that they are not "spiritual." At times they represent no little spirit.

Guiding Principles are principles of church polity. Pastor Caspersen has come into a tremendously mystical vein when in certain articles in *Folkebladet* he maintains that the question 'Do you want a congregation?' and 'Guiding Principles' concern the person as such, or that sets forth a "new type of Christian." It is almost incomprehensible that a man with theological formation can write such a thing.

Quite otherwise thought, wrote, and spoke Pastor E. Lou, who knew his Bible as few among us did, and who kept up with theology and labored zealously as perhaps none of us did. Lou



wrote an immense amount in former days in *Luthersk Kirkeblad* and in *Folkebladet*. He both thought and theologized, but in an altogether different, sober, unpretentious manner. In June 1914, when he reviewed *Guide to the Free Church's Principles*, he wrote in *Folkebladet*:

If the people of the Free Church do not agree on this, that the principles are matters of church polity, then the Free Church's days are numbered.

Words almost prophetic, whose fulfillment perhaps lies nearer than many think.

And this was not Lou's view only in 1914. In the last letter he wrote to me, shortly before his death — and I have permission to quote him — he said: “We agree that the principles are matters of church polity and not an exhortation to ‘awakening’ in this word's meaning, as the ‘awakened’ understand it.”

Now it may well be rather indifferent what we call the principles. If we had called them practical theology, that name would doubtless have given less offense than the more precise term principles of church polity, for church polity is, after all, a part of practical theology.

But since exceedingly different understandings of the principles prevail with respect to what they mean — and as to their value there will always be difference of opinion — it is surely right that they be made the object of discussion until agreement is reached on what they actually entail. For the Free Church gains little by having principles that mean one thing to some, another thing to others. It is meaningless to connect them with a “new type of Christian,” and it is likewise meaningless to confuse the Free Church's task or purpose with its principles. The key to their understanding lies in the literature of church polity.

Pastor Holck in Norway, one of the friends of reform, who in his day wrote much about questions of church polity, wrote in the 1870s: “Indirectly it has been stated that the supreme principle for the church must be to look to its own welfare, to its purpose, to bring souls to salvation, and that to this concern every other consideration must give way. In spite of its appearance of truth, this rests upon a manifest misunderstanding. To advance the church's purpose, the salvation of souls, can never become a principle in the same sense in which religious liberty is one; it is a task that is to be solved.”

When I hear that the principles are time and again classified under “spirit and life” and similar slogans, I see a picture: a schoolman lays four open books on a table, all in the English language; the one book treats astronomy, the second physiology, the third physics, and the fourth philosophy. “This is astronomy,” says the schoolman, “this is physiology, this is physics, this is philosophy.” No and again no, comes the answer from a stubborn onlooker: “It is neither the one nor the other: it is all English!” There is no making anything precise

for such a fellow.<sup>6</sup>

But if we could agree that the principles concern church polity, would that mean that the Free Church's chief task is to labor for church polity?

No, every church's foremost task must be the salvation of souls. But if that were all that mattered, then one could simply refrain from organizing congregations, let alone associations of congregations. There must be something more.

In the Free Church's Rules — rules are not the same as principles — we read that the purpose of the association called the Lutheran Free Church is to labor “for the quickening and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations.” Is it only the awakening and salvation of souls that are here being aimed at?

Those who authored the principles should here be allowed to speak. Sverdrup wrote: “It is not merely a question of awakening the individual conscience. It is not solely the task to bring the individual to the Savior. The task is to awaken consciousness of the congregation's essence and calling, by the power of the Word and the Spirit, to build up and people the body of Christ.” (Collected Writings III.)

And in other places he writes of the manifestation of the body of Christ, that the congregation shall win its proper position among us, and so forth.

It is the duty of all Christians to labor for the quickening and liberation of individuals. But it is not thereby said that this, without more ado, means “the quickening and liberation of the congregations.” In Norway much Christian work is done — I am inclined to think that there is even more fear of God among the church people there than among us. But in spite of this Sverdrup would not admit that in the Norwegian state church there are congregations in the proper sense of the word. I do not state my own opinion here, but Sverdrup's — and precisely in order to shed light on the principles. After a visit to Norway in 1886 Sverdrup wrote this:

The state church has too little room for Christian and ecclesiastical work.... There is no congregation in the proper sense of the word in which there is room for all gifts and use for all hands. If some Christian man or woman feels a call and inclination to some work, then they must break their own way on their own. There is no one who marks out the field of labor for them....

Naturally there is room for many works of love and much self-sacrifice in family life, in the school, in private intercourse with people. But the actual specifically

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<sup>6</sup>Historically offensive content removed.

Christian field of labor is lacking, the congregation, the body of Jesus Christ. In all outward respects it is so bound by law, and in a certain sense so fatherly provided for by the state, that there is no room for the Christians' self-sacrificing labor for it.

Christian people who come from Norway to America often find that the brethren in the Free Church are so dry and cold, so filled with busyness, that it is almost doubtful whether they can really have any true heart Christianity, any inward life in God. They seem far too outwardly oriented and absorbed in work.

Conversely, he who comes from America to Norway gets the impression that Christianity is chiefly feeling, inwardness, contemplation, thought, but little or no work....

But it would be altogether unjust to conclude from this that there is therefore less true and honest fear of God in the one place than in the other."

Thus: the fear of God is to be equally true and honest in both lands. And yet: no congregation in the proper sense of the word in Norway.

How then can the sort of language we hear so much of be grounded in Sverdrup, language which says that if only souls are converted and brought to God, then one is thereby, simply, laboring for the quickening and liberation of the congregation?

Certainly, one must begin with individuals, but one cannot remain standing with individuals. If there should be found a little congregation in which all were believers, could one then say that it did not need to be counted among those congregations to which the Free Church refers when in its rules it speaks of "the vivification and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations"?

No, according to the Augsburg Confession's understanding of the congregation, something more is required: there must be labor so that the congregation becomes a visible congregation, which, because it bears the name of the invisible congregation, must correspond to that name.

Therefore it is not consistent to say that the organizations are indifferent. But it is tempting to speak thus, which Sverdrup also emphasizes when he says:

In the New Testament such high and holy words are spoken about the congregation that many have given it up in despair and have sought to escape from the holy demand by teaching that all the great and glorious things are said about an invisible congregation, and that is — another matter."

The body of Christ, that whereby Christ is seen, that through which Christ works, is visible, because it is believing men and women who labor with the Word and the Sacraments, and it is precisely these outwardly organized fellowships that are called congregations.” (1897.)

Here the Norwegian Lutheran Free Church distinguishes itself from the “societies” and the “people’s churches” and the “state churches,” which make the congregations into wholly subordinate members of the larger organizations or at any rate do not set them higher than these organizations. The Free Church regards the local congregation as a divine institution; it regards the other organizations as human arrangements.

Pastor P. L. Tangjerd has in *Four Hundred Years of Lutheranism* criticized the Free Church for this. He says that sentences such as “the congregation is of divine origin, but the association is of human origin,” “the local congregation is the proper form of the kingdom of God on earth” — are “suited to confuse the concepts.”

He continues:

“What is a congregation? Disciples gathered around the means of grace (‘two or three in Jesus’ name’). Whether they have an outward organization, how long the gathering lasts, how near one another the disciples live, and so forth, makes no difference. An annual meeting of the church body is, in the biblical sense, just as much a congregation as any local congregation within it. Both are equally much and equally little ‘instituted by God’ and ‘the proper form of the kingdom of God on earth’.... ‘Congregation’ and ‘association’ stand side by side with respect to divine institution....

### 1.3 Installment 3: “Folkebladet” March 27, 1918

The Free Church says only this: the congregation is divinely instituted. No, say the others.

It is precisely here that the Free Church’s kinship with the Congregationalists shows itself. The distinctive function of the Congregationalists is “to reveal and to realise the true idea of the church.” In an English author we read this:

“Dr. R. W. Dale, in an essay written ..... years ago, closes with a statement of what he considered to be ‘the distinctive function’ of Congregationalists.

“It was he thought, not the work of Evangelisation, for that is the work alike of all Christians; still less was it the work of testifying against the evils, real or supposed, of other churches—for example, the evil of ‘ecclesiastical establishment’; nor was it the work of reconstructing theological science, or taking a chief place in the controversy with unbelief. All such work may form a part of their duty, and sometimes an inevitable part. But their distinctive function is ‘to reveal and to realise the true idea of the Church.’”

One must not misunderstand such an analogy (or one like it). Such a misunderstanding seems to be contained in the “Kristelig Folkekalender” for 1917, page 43, where it is said: “The mission of the Free Church, then, is not first and foremost to assert the congregational principle of polity among us Norwegian Lutherans, but rather to labor for the enlivening and liberation of the congregations.”

This is no doubt meant as a correction addressed to me. But I have not ascribed that task to the Free Church. I have only said that the distinctiveness of the Free Church among Lutherans lies in the sphere of polity, and that its principles of polity resemble those of the Congregationalists very closely, which Professor J. O. Andersen at the University of Copenhagen also maintains in his article on Sverdrup in “Kirkeleksikon for Norden” (three columns in fascicle 66, year 1917): “The new C. (the Free Church) was ordered according to decidedly Congregationalist principles.” I ought to add that Andersen in this connection speaks of the Principles and Rules, and that he has “Collected Writings.” Further, that Andersen, as author of a larger work on church organization, understands tolerably well what Congregationalist principles are.

Distinctiveness, I said; not task. There is a difference between these two things. There are, for example, one hundred students at a school. One of them is a Negro; the others are white. There is something distinctive about the one: he is black. But we will not say that it is first and foremost his task to be black.

The distinctiveness of the Free Church among Lutherans lies in the sphere of polity. But since

it has essentially the same principles of polity as the Congregationalists, it may also be said of it that it has the same “distinctive function.” For the Free Church is not a congregation, but an association of congregations which takes upon itself tasks that the individual congregation cannot well solve alone.

The distinctive function of the Free Church is to bring the congregation forth in its proper form, or “to reveal and realise the true idea of the church.” Therefore it declares as its purpose “to labor for the enlivening and liberation of all Norwegian Lutheran congregations, so that according to their calling and ability they may work in spiritual independence and freedom for the cause of God’s kingdom at home and abroad ....” (Rule 2).

And how is this purpose sought attained? Is it by constantly preaching awakening? Rule 3 says: “This purpose is sought attained chiefly by the training of men and women for spiritual labor in and for the congregation, by the holding of greater and smaller meetings, by the dissemination of suitable literature, by the organization of Free-Church committees and associations, by the sending out of emissaries, and by other means which from time to time may show themselves expedient.”

Nota bene—emissaries as well. Paa.t. Nilsen is no doubt not altogether in agreement with Rule 3. For he says in the previous issue of this paper: the work of emissaries “will become a foreign plant in the Free-Church soil.”

Now the editors will scarcely be among those who compare the distinctive function of the Free Church with that of the Congregationalists. And yet it seems that what the Congregationalists call their distinctive function, “to reveal and to realise the true idea of the church,” becomes a main matter, indeed the main matter, for the editors. “The main matter for us is that the congregation come forth in its proper form.” (Folkebladet no. 34.)

And yet we read this: “We know, however, that according to God’s Word there is a congregation where two or three are gathered in Jesus’ name .... or where two or more believers are gathered around God’s Word and the sacraments. The fact that a group of people forms an association does not create any congregation, but the fact that souls come to life in God. For us in the Free Church, who have this view, the organization is of less importance.” (The Editors.)

Here it is suggested that the main thing is that souls come to life in God, whereas just before it is said that the main thing is that the congregation receive its proper form. Presumably this is meant to signify the same thing. If it does not do so for the editors, then it does so for many in the Free Church.

But this is not the view of the Principles. In his explanation of Principle No. 1, S. says: “And next to the question of the salvation of the individual soul, there is no more important question than that of the congregation.”

Thus, two questions.

Now we know that the first is included in the second; but the second is not without remainder included in the first. We know also that Sverdrup used the word awakening in a very comprehensive sense: the gifts of grace too were to be awakened. And therefore he could say: “That which is really the main thing in the free congregation, and which we cannot stress often enough, is the unfolding and right use of the gifts of grace” (C. W. II).

That souls come to life in God does not without more ado mean that the gifts of grace are unfolded and taken into use, and that there is a congregation in the sense of the Principles.

To be sure, the congregation may be present according to its essence, but Sverdrup also wants it to be present according to its form—its proper form.

Hans Nielsen Hauge was a great instrument in the Lord’s hand for leading souls to God. But a congregation according to the demands of the New Testament he could not form, says Sverdrup (C. W. II, 207). The congregation did not receive its proper form in Norway—not through Hauge and not through Johnsen. For Sverdrup reproaches the Johansen revival for having too little sense for the congregation: “In this whole movement there was lacking the right view of the congregation .... or of Jesus Christ’s body” (C. W. I, 200).

Thus: according to Sverdrup’s view, the congregation’s proper form does not come of itself from what we commonly understand by awakening and conversion.

In all churchly and Free-Church work the salvation of the individual is surely a main matter. But no society would presume to claim that this is its distinctive function. A function that is common to many or to all is distinctive for none.

The principles of the Free Church are distinctive; and the task of the Free Church, which is first mentioned in the Rules (not in the Principles), is distinctive as its function is.

The most important thing for us all—and of this we are surely heartily agreed—is the salvation of the individual. But the Free Church believes that the work for the individual’s salvation and preservation in the life, and for spiritual activity, may be better promoted by means of the realization of the Principles, especially Principle No. 1, that principle of which S. said: “The Free Church’s proper main principle is this, that the congregation is the right divine order within the Christian religion” (Guide 143).

I will not say that the editors deny the legitimacy of the local congregation. Quite the contrary. But they do not let the Augsburg understanding of the congregation come clearly forth. The congregation becomes something indefinite, nearest to the holy catholic church or the communion of saints. And congregational work becomes nearest to mission work, going out to bring souls to life in God.

Now I will not in these observations express my opinion as to whether the line of thought the editors seem to represent is less or more biblical than that represented by Principle No. 1. I do not here set myself up as judge between right and wrong. But I do think that there is some difference in the line of thought.

My position is this: First it is a matter of becoming clear on what the Augsburg understanding of the congregation is. And later there may be occasion to test it in the light of God's Word. And in this testing by the Word, it is not persons that matter, but the Word alone.

For the present, the following may deserve our consideration: Is there a congregation where two or three are gathered in Jesus' name?

Yes, says Luther, for whom the church was an organism of all believers on earth, but no organization.

Yes, says Luther, who held that if all believers on earth died, and he were left alone, then he was the church.

Yes, says Luther, who never spoke of the enlivening of the congregation and never spoke of dead members of the congregation. For his church was a religious, a spiritual magnitude, independent of the boundaries of time and space, independent of outward organization and form. The holy catholic church, he said, consisted only of believers: it is invisible to others; they cannot grasp that on earth there is a gathering of believing people who are bound together not by rule, right, or law, but by the bonds of freedom, Christ's Spirit. This gathering or congregation is visible only to believers. They apprehend the unity, this unity of the Spirit; but they cannot point to anything concrete and say: Here is the church. For the church is the work of the Holy Spirit. Everything outward, whether it is called congregation or church, is not church in the biblical sense. Organizations are indeed psychologically necessary, but they are of a worldly (here not sinful) nature. The church, or God's congregation, is not bound to time, place, organization. This, at any rate, is what the four-hundredth anniversary of the Reformation has sought to establish concerning Luther. I cannot develop this more fully now.

But no, says Sverdrup: the word about "the two or three" is not really spoken concerning the congregation. "If one would apply the word about two or three to the congregation, then



the result would be this: if in a place there were no more than two or three believers, then these were nevertheless many enough to be a congregation” (C. W. II, 196).

No, says Sverdrup: Luther’s word in the Third Article concerning the “whole Christian congregation on earth” must also be true of each individual congregation, if this is really to answer to its name. “The congregation consists of the believers in each place, who there in that place have formed an organization in order to labor in God’s kingdom” (Guide 143).

No, says Sverdrup: a believing missionary in a heathen land is no congregation. And he and an assembly of converted people are no congregation, but only a mission.

And no, says Oftedal: “For Paul and the other New-Testament writers the congregation too does not stand as something loose and indefinite, something invisible and general—the believers, wherever they might be found, without regard to their outward visible union and assembly; but it stands as a defined circle consisting of men and women separated from the rest of the world by their ordering and by the word and the Spirit whereby they had been separated” (Guide 74). In another place we read that it belongs to the essence of the church to consist in the form of congregations, not as individual Christian persons (1875).

## 1.4 Installment 4: “Folkebladet” April 3, 1918

It will thus be seen that principle no. 1, "the proper chief principle of Scripture" (Veiledning, 143), is by no means a small matter. It is anything but a devout manner of speaking. Its rejection would, to a greater or lesser extent, modify the other fundamental propositions concerning church polity.

The Guiding Principles have again and again been attacked as being at variance with the New Testament's teaching concerning the congregation. And in these attacks there has been no lack of proofs from Scripture. I mean that the thoughts which the Guiding Principles interpret, and the consequences which they involve, have fairly often and quite thoroughly been treated in the literature on church polity. The arguments have been both for and against—indirectly against, where Scripture has been broken in order to prove the supposed scriptural warrant for another concept of the church. For Norway's part it is enough to point to a great number of articles in *Luthersk Kirketidende*, in *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*, and in *Luthersk Ugeskrift*. Germany has a large body of material to offer in its many works on ecclesiastical law and in innumerable contributions interpreting the most various church-political views. And the English Reformed literature on church polity is very extensive.

If we take up principle no. 1, we may first mention Professor von Oettingen (d. 1905) in Dorpat. He was known as a capable Lutheran dogmatician. But he unconditionally rejected the opinion that the New Testament knows only local congregations and contains no "doctrine of the church."

The teacher of ecclesiastical law, Professor Sohm, too, has several times, with good use of passages from Scripture, polemicized against that which principle no. 1 seeks to establish. As the best authority on Luther among jurists, he assures us that Luther could never have agreed with such a principle.

The church historian Professor Wm. Walter of Rostock, unquestionably the leading living authority on Luther among theologians, says the same of Luther and assures us that Jesus himself could not teach anything such as principle no. 1 teaches: it is too exclusive. (Ev. Luth. Kirchenzeitung, 1913.)

It is in the Reformed literature on church polity that principle no. 1 receives its strongest support. In the Lutheran it receives but little assent. I do not know of a single Lutheran theological faculty of rank in the whole world that would vote for it.

Nor do I know many Lutheran theologians (Professor Odland and Jens Greve must be counted among the exceptions) who agree that this principle is grounded in the New Testament. The

great majority regard it as Reformed and will doubtless agree with the teacher of ecclesiastical law, Stahl, when he says: "The Reformed church has a strong tendency to let the concept of church pass over into the concept of congregation; it comes to that completely—in its offshoots, the Independents and Baptists, and so forth."

If one wishes to see how the principles of church polity in the Reformed church are judged by Lutherans, one does well to read Sohm's *Kirchenrecht*, pp. 634–657, and especially the jurist Karl Rieter's *Grundsätze reformierter Kirchenverfassung* (about 200 pages), a work that will cast a surprising light upon the Guiding Principles and their consistent interpretation.

But we need not stop with the German Lutherans. We may point to Norway. In 1915–16 a lively discussion concerning the concept of the church was carried on in *Luthersk Kirketidende*. It was between schoolmaster Jens Greve and parish pastor H. U. Sverdrup. Greve maintained the Free Church concept of the church, while H. U. Sverdrup rejected it. Both men are known as friends of the work for spirit and life.

Greve says:

"If we ask where the church is to be found on earth, then, according to our confession, we ask: Where is the Word preached purely, where are the Sacraments rightly administered? And where we find that this takes place, there we recognize the congregation to be. But then we turn our gaze to the local congregation; we cannot turn it elsewhere; even if it consisted of only two or three gathered in Jesus' name, we must in it see the church made manifest. Greve teaches that the visible forms of manifestation are the church's forms of manifestation, and that accordingly the true church of Jesus Christ in empirical reality comes forth in the visible congregations, there where the Word is preached purely and the Sacraments rightly administered. In other words: Not in an ecclesiastical organization embracing all Christians, nor yet in a mighty hierarchical order with a pope as supreme head, do we find the church, but in the local congregations, where the Word is rightly preached, etc., even where only two or three are assembled in Jesus' name. We must acknowledge such an assembly, gathered around Word and Sacrament, as a congregation of Christ, a congregation of God; in such a congregation we see "the communion of saints," "the body of Christ," made manifest in a visible form of existence on earth."

This means: according to Scripture, the congregation is the right form of the kingdom of God on earth—which is precisely what the adherents of the state church and of the people's church reject. Therefore Greve says:

"What, at bottom, is the fault among both the men of the state church and the adherents of the national church? They raise their building upon a foundation that fails; they build upon a false concept of the church," etc.

To this H. U. Sverdrup replies:

"I maintain that in ordinary Norwegian this can only mean that in the constitutional question the men of the state church and the adherents of the national church are, broadly speaking, one, only that the men of the state church, or their theories, are perhaps a little worse in any case, for they are altogether impossible."

Greve maintains that there is only one form of manifestation for the body of Christ. It is precisely the local congregation that is the body of Christ.

H. U. Sverdrup, on the other hand, maintains that there are many kinds of forms of manifestation. No visible form of existence can claim to be the body of Christ. He says:

"The Lutheran concept of the church has, within the evangelical division of the church, allowed itself to be joined with the most various forms of polity, the free-church forms as well, provided only that these, like this concept of the church itself, are of a folk-church character. The 'free-church concept' leads by inward consequence to the voluntaristic church with congregational order. For biblical and Lutheran thought, the legitimacy of the Free Church is dependent upon special conditions (the time of beginnings, the time of persecution, the end time); and since these conditions are always something that the church must seek to overcome, the Free Church (that is, the voluntaristic Free Church) will never stand as a goal that for principal reasons ought to be striven after. But this is precisely what the 'free-churchmen,' by virtue of their concept of the church, do. And indeed to such a degree that they designate the folk-church formation of the church as a deep fall."

H. U. Sverdrup thus rejects that line of thought which makes the church's outward organization something essential. Indeed he says:

"The concept of the free-churchmen is neither Lutheran, nor ancient-church, nor biblical, whereas the concept of the church among the adherents of the state church and of the folk church—precisely in the essential point that the church as the communion of saints, as the body of Christ, is invisible, and that it cannot in any visible form of existence claim to be this—agrees both with the Lutheran confession, the ancient-church conception, and with Scripture."

Thus: the foregoing shows that there is fairly strong opposition to principle no. 1. It would be too lengthy to illuminate the other principles in this manner. Those who wish to have them illuminated will find them illuminated in the literature on church polity.

The Guiding Principles do not stand alone. But there lies a whole history behind them. They attempt to apply the Reformation principle of "the universal priesthood" to the local congregation and to the relation between the local congregations. The reason they are so little understood among us is doubtless the high-church upbringing which has entered into the blood even of many of the ablest and most zealous spokesmen of the revival: that direction which has set its stamp upon Krogh-Tønning's doctrinal theology has also strongly influenced the home, religious instruction, the pulpit, the church press, indeed the whole of Christian thinking.

There are doubtless several directions that have been negatively determinative for the Guiding Principles. Thus the high-church tendency in Norway, with men like Heuch and Bugge at its head and with its many heirs in this country. We need not enter into these tendencies, but will only say that the the Guiding Principles have sought to take a stand against them.

It is of importance just now that we become more closely acquainted with the directions which, theoretically considered, have been positively determinative for the formulation of the principles and for the interpretation which their authors have given them.

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If I am not mistaken, the authors have been influenced by four closely related currents:

1. The authors were strongly influenced by the church reform movement in Western Norway. In principle it recognized lay activity as something that normally belongs in an evangelical congregation. It maintained a democratic view of the ministerial office. It taught that all ecclesiastical right has its root in the congregation. In other words: "it championed the cause of religious liberty and congregational liberty" (Samlede Skrifter II, 201–211). This tendency found early expression in *Luthersk Kirketidende*. Later it received its organ in *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*, edited by Jakob Sverdrup and O. Vollan (1877–81). It was zealously opposed by *Luthersk Ugeskrift*, edited by Bugge and Heuch, who were then high-church.

To those who wish to know what polity is, we recommend *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*. Krogh-Tønning polemicized much against this paper and wrote of it in 1880: "The paper concerns itself almost exclusively with its favorite ideas about reforms in church polity; and it is precisely these that can only be explained by Reformed spirit, the spirit of independentism." He meant that the paper had fixed its gaze so blindly upon evangelical freedom that it had

no sight for ecclesiastical authority; it had "a concept of the Christians' spiritual priesthood which is at variance with the concept of the special priesthood"; it shut itself off from the truth that the office is instituted by God; it lacked the view of Jesus Christ's church as the 'one' and 'catholic'; and without further ado, in independentist fashion, transferred all right and power to the single local congregation. So much for Tønning.

2. Sverdrup and Oftedal nevertheless went further than the reform movement, for which the congregation was only the center of gravity in the ecclesiastical organization. They made the congregation the church itself, the only right form of the kingdom of God on earth. According to S. and O., the local congregation is an institution *de jure divino*.

But this is precisely the doctrine of the older Congregationalists (down to about 1870), although the newer school of Congregationalists maintains that there is no prescribed church form in the New Testament. To be sure, it finds no other church form in the New Testament than the local congregation, but it no longer constructs a *de jure divino* church polity on this basis. At the very most it regards the congregational form as something recommended, but not as something commanded. These are the ideas of the newer school, whereas S. and O. follow the old one with respect to the idea of the congregation's divine institution.

The Congregationalists also went a step further than the reform party did in the democratic understanding of the ministerial office. They were very free with regard to lay activity and had no objection to a layman's administering the Sacraments on the congregation's behalf. But with respect both to the reception of members into the congregation and to church discipline, they were legal-minded, and therefore in this area diverged from S. and O., who here sought, as far as possible, to preserve evangelical freedom. In this respect the Congregationalists were more consistent than S. and O., who thought that logic must bend to life, although others object that principle no. 1 is a false premise, where life in reality bends to logic.

If S. and O. held the older Congregationalists' view of principle no. 1 (the congregation is the right form) and of the equality of the members within the congregational body, they also shared their view with regard to the relation between the congregations. In his address "Free association among free congregations," 1897, Oftedal declared that the Lutheran Free Church, in the sense presented in his address, was "truly the old, good church order given of itself by the Word of God, in contrast to clerical rule, communal tyranny, and the state-church system."

How far S. and O. had acquainted themselves with the church polity of the Congregationalists (and Baptists) is not easy to determine. It is possible that they did not concern themselves much further with it, although Oftedal, as a church historian, must surely have known a good

deal of it. It is possible that they took counsel with little besides the New Testament. In any case, Norway, despite the Haugean and Johnsonian revival, had not taught them much about the congregation. "There was no one in Norway," said Sverdrup, "who taught us anything about the free congregation or the true nature and form of Christ's church, so that we all came over here rather unenlightened and without understanding in the things that belong to a free church fellowship" (S. S. II, 101).

But one thing must not be left unsaid. Oftedal and Sverdrup used the same arguments to prove the scripturalness of their conception of the congregation and of their view of the office, lay activity, and church organization as the Congregationalists did. The patterns of argument are remarkably similar, which they can only be when the presuppositions are the same. This applies not only to their marshalling of scriptural proof, but also to the polemic against the arguments which the opponents of the congregational principle have brought into the field. Everything converged on the claim that the congregation is Christ's body, that it is therefore free and independent, that the other ecclesiastical organizations are human arrangements, and that the universal priesthood receives its application precisely in the congregation.

## 1.5 Installment 5: “Folkebladet,” April 10, 1918

The Congregationalists’ corresponding treatment of these matters is found in the literature which they call church polity. Oftedal too is content with this term: he uses it four times in his short affidavit concerning the Open Declaration (*Veiledning*, 198 ff).<sup>7</sup>

It is not I who have put this expression in their mouths. I ought also to add that it is not I who furnished the books on that six-foot-long constitutional shelf, of which I wrote, with the name *kirkeforfatning*, or church polity. They have this name on their title-pages. It is natural enough for the average churchgoer to think that this name has chiefly to do with legal provisions, laws, and rules concerning the church. But a theologian who knows nothing more and better about the “field” deserves our undivided sympathy and a heartfelt wish for improvement.

3. S. and O. have also been influenced by the biblicistic tendency whose original spokesman was J. T. Beck. The second volume of his ethics devotes about 50 pages to “The Christian Congregation’s Constitution” (the heading). In 27 pages Beck treats what he calls the “principles” or the “inner constitution.” Under the heading of the “outer constitution” he treats the gifts of grace. Beck’s conception of the local congregation is more like that of the Norwegian reform advocates than that of the Congregationalists. But his pronounced biblicism, his strong emphasis on the gifts of grace (in this he represents an advance beyond the reform advocates and the older Congregationalists), together with his sharp judgments upon the congregations, that they had progressed no further than the stage of mission congregations, are factors that have been determinative for Guiding Principles.

4. S. and O. also have much in common with the eminent Lutheran jurist Rudolph Sohm,<sup>8</sup> who, more vigorously than Beck, places the emphasis on the charismatic organization (the church’s organization by the gifts of grace) and upon the freedom of the Spirit in contrast to everything that is juridical. Sverdrup’s words, “with the diversity of the gifts of grace and their right use, the freedom of the Spirit wins its true triumph,” are a genuinely Sohmian sentence.

Whereas Sverdrup places the emphasis on the use of the gifts of grace essentially in the local congregation, Sohm finds that the local congregation is altogether too narrow for this purpose.

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<sup>7</sup>(1897) STATE OF MINNESOTA; COUNTY OF HENNEPIN. DISTRICT COURT; FOURTH JUDICIAL DISTRICT. In the Matter of the Application of Nils C. Brun, Lauritz F. Clausen, Lars Swenson, Orson A. Veblen and Ole O. Aanstad, for leave to File an Information, in the nature of quo warranto, against Sven Oftedal, Olaf Hoff, Ole Paulson, Theodore Helgesen and Andrew Knutson.

<sup>8</sup>Wikipedia: Gotthold Julius Rudolph Sohm (29 October 1841 in Rostock – 16 May 1917 in Leipzig) was a German jurist and Church historian as well as a theologian.



He maintains that the holy catholic church, the communion of saints, without regard to organization, is the place for their use. To be sure, Sverdrup would not have asserted that every organization which calls itself a congregation has the right to determine whether the Christian shall use his gift of grace or not (II, 314). But he held fast in principle to this, that “without the congregation, the gifts of grace have no attachment and no purpose” (*Luth. Kirkeblad* 1893). He regarded, for example, “Christian lay activity as one of the most precious gifts of grace in our time” (there).

With respect to Sverdrup’s mild conditions for the reception of members into the congregation, and his likewise mild doctrine of church discipline, this is as characteristically Sohm as it can be in one who, differing from Sohm, taught that “the congregation is the proper form,” and that all the glorious things which are said about the church, the communion of saints, in Sohm’s brilliant, spirited work *Church Law*, are to apply to the local congregation.

Sohm regards the church as wholly and entirely religious, an organism, not an organization; that is to say, the congregation is not any local organization, no organized church body, no state church, no confessional church (denomination); but it is God’s people on earth, the body of Christ, the work of the Holy Spirit. “Local congregations” and other ecclesiastical organizations are indeed necessary, but none of them is holy. They are no more “holy” or more “church” than any other organization which men have agreed to form and maintain.

Here Sohm departs from Sverdrup, who according to *Samlede Skrifter* (II, 5) called “the holiness of the congregation” “the real main question in the Free Church. ”Indeed, Sverdrup went so far as to say that the cause of the American doctrinal controversy was that people had different conceptions of the congregation.” “But behind the doctrinal controversy too there has lurked a different conception of the congregation and of its composition and work” (II, C, 7).

Sohm does not like the word church law or church polity, because he means that the church cannot be organized: the body of Christ cannot have juridical determinations imposed upon it; the outward ecclesiastical system is, strictly speaking, no church system at all, and therefore its juridical norms (all law is formal, coercive) are a contradiction of the essence of freedom. His well-known thesis concerning church law therefore runs thus: “All church law is a contradiction of the essence of the church.” The congregation, he teaches, is no definite empirical entity, no social concept in general; it is a spiritual reality raised above earthly norms; it withdraws from the dominion of “law” and is unfit for juridical organization. (Luther’s view.)

Although Sohm rejects the expressions “church law” and “church polity,” yet he does bow

to common usage and writes an epoch-making work with the title *Church Law*. If one will accept Sohm's rejection of these expressions, then one must also adopt his definition of "law" (which jurists as a rule will not do) and understand the main principle of the Free Church movement.

Meanwhile one cannot all at once change the name of the literature which casts the strongest light upon principles such as Guiding Principles, or even upon Sohm's own ecclesiastical views. After all, it is not so much the name that matters as the benefit—the benefit of consulting literature on church polity in order to see whether Guiding Principles stands or fails. For in this literature there is a wealth of contributions for and against the norms and forms that determine the ways in which the church becomes manifest, its inner and outer life. Most of these contributions will be built upon Scripture or upon history or upon both. It is characteristic that the pastor J. J. Jansen (Nøsen)<sup>9</sup> relates that when he wished to write about the concept of church and office, he turned to church law (he names a full dozen authors) there to "study, understand, and first arrive at a conclusion about what the New Testament teaches concerning the office." It may seem to be a strange way of studying the New Testament—by a roundabout way. But Jansen doubtless knew what he was doing.

But back to Sohm. S. and O. had their ecclesiastical views essentially ready long before Sohm came forth with his in 1892. Yet it cannot be denied that Sverdrup found in Sohm a powerful support for his conception of the gifts of grace and the freedom of the Spirit. For after 1892 he was much more forceful in advancing it than before. And many of his ablest articles bear witness—linguistically as well—to influence from Sohm.

In Oftedal there are fewer traces of this influence. But Oftedal, on the other hand, had from earlier days been strongly influenced by Professor Michael Baumgarten,<sup>10</sup> who—as Professor Hansleiter points out (*Herzog-Hauck's Encyclopædie* II, 461)—was a kind of forerunner of Sohm. Baumgarten could say: "God grant we had never got a church law. We should then long ago have had a 'spiritual' church order."

Baumgarten was one of Germany's most zealous champions of free-church ideas, and believed in what he called "the autonomy of the saints." He felt nothing but aversion toward the connection between state and church, laid stress upon the freedom and inwardness of faith, hated all coercion and legalism. He taught that the church ought to use the apostolic writings as its standard also for church government: there ought to be an apostolic church polity. It was chiefly the latter that caused the church historian Kliefoth to secure from the

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<sup>9</sup>FIXME: Jansen, Jens Jonas Elstrand ?

<sup>10</sup>Wikipedia: Michael Baumgarten (25 March 1812 – 21 July 1889) was a German Protestant theologian. Baumgarten was born at Haseldorf in Schleswig-Holstein.

Duke of Mecklenburg Baumgarten's dismissal as theological professor at the University of Rostock. In his understanding of the Acts of the Apostles Oftedal was markedly influenced by Baumgarten's work on apostolic history (1858), which is not difficult to demonstrate.

These four currents—the reform movement, Congregationalism, the Beckian current, and the Sohmian current—the authors of the Principles have taken into account. The kinship is greatest, however, with the Congregationalists, and next with Sohm, despite the fact that Sohm denies principle no. 1.

**I do not hesitate to say that I cannot see how anyone can rightly assess Sverdrup's ecclesiastical views unless he acquaints himself with the literature on church polity of the older Congregationalists and with Sohm's works on church law.**

To suggest something of this sort—that one must read certain writings, not authored by S. and O., in order rightly to understand these writings authored by S. and O—can hardly do otherwise than have an irritating effect. I know that very well. But as one who has “made the attempt,” and thus speaks from a little experience, I am free enough to say it. For among us too there are those who read the principles and interpret them just as a Jew reads his Old Testament through the books of Moses, absolutely certain that they have the right understanding, that they see the thread running through it, and that they have no need of guidance.

I especially single out Sohm. He can indeed be of real help to anyone not too proud to learn from him. If the recommendation I give him does not suffice, then perhaps the following from a pastor in Norway will be acceptable:

“It is . . . Sohm's great merit to have vindicated the great significance of the pneumatic-charismatic element (*pneuma* = spirit, *charisma* = gift of grace) in the constitution of the ancient church. He has found the right point of departure for understanding what is characteristic and unique in the church's formation as a communal body, and thereby has become able, with unsurpassed clarity and sharpness, to set forth the constitutional-historical problems which here call for the attention of research.

“One's heart can be seized by the lofty idealism in Sohm's thoughts. One feels how he suffers under the church's dualism, how it pains him to see the element of law bring a foreign and dangerous spirit into the church's development, how he longs for harmony and clarity. And in all his work one particularly notices how he burns with zeal to bring God glory and let his Spirit be the church's only Lord and ruler. He would cleanse the alien elements out of God's house and make

earnest of the fact that this shall be the Lord's body and a spiritual temple built of living stones."

How strongly this recalls Sverdrup's statement: "That which is really the principal matter in the free congregation, and which we cannot stress often enough, is the unfolding and right use of the gifts of grace." Or, "with the diversity of the gifts of grace and their right use, the freedom of the Spirit wins its true triumph" (S. S. II).

The longer Sverdrup wrote, the more he tended toward Sohm. And it is possible that Sohm's new work of 1914, which represents an intense labor continued all the way from 1892, when his first volume on church law appeared, might have led Sverdrup to modify his view with respect to principle no. 1. Their line of thought is very similar; agreement in the implications seems unavoidable.

One of Sohm's colleagues defines the concept of the church as follows:

"§ 1. The church is a religious reality, God's people, the body of Christ. It has its citizenship in heaven and has there its home. But in this church God's redeeming will is carried out in humanity here on earth. § 2. Therefore the church here on earth appears in the form of a community: a communal life. This form, however imperfect it may be, is essential for the church. Consequently the communal aspect is more than a 'support and help'; it belongs to the very concept of the church, and is the form in which the church of faith is realized, in so far as it can be realized here in the world."

Sohm and Sverdrup would agree in § 1.

Sohm would reject § 2 and say that this "form" is not essential for the church, does not belong to the very concept of the church, but is only a support and help. Sverdrup would have endorsed § 2, but on the condition that "form" means the local congregation, and that all other outward ecclesiastical organizations are "support and help," or else obstruction and hindrance, depending on the circumstances.

## 1.6 Installment 6: “Folkebladet,” April 17, 1918

Whoever has read the significant work of the Swedish professor Gustaf Aulen from 1912, “The Lutheran Church-Idea,” in which the author deals with the Lutheran concept of the church as well as the ‘Lundensian’ and ‘Uppsalian’ concepts of the church, will have noticed a quotation in the preface from one of Scotland’s leading churchmen, John Cairns (died 1892). Cairns says:

With all that the labour of the theologians has done to define and vindicate the idea of the church, I believe that we are as yet only on the surface of its depths.

I think Cairns would have appreciated Sohm’s treatment of the church. Yes, I think he would also have rejoiced over the “guiding principles,” though they do not go so far as Sohm.

One thing must now be clear. The guiding principles and that which their authors have written concerning them must be studied, discussed, and clarified—at least in private. If one immerses oneself in these principles, then a hundred questions will arise, and one will scarcely give up before one has received satisfactory answers from the authors. If, in addition, one reads related literature written by others, then new points of view emerge; and one then returns to the principles with these, makes comparisons, and forms for oneself a comprehensive view in which no details have been skipped over, nothing foreign has been imported, and the greater and the lesser have received their proper importance and their proper place.

It is not for everyone to do this work. Where prejudice has anchored itself fast, where intellectual alertness is dull, indifference great, and the assertion “We have Abraham as our father” strong, there the prospects for a fruitful engagement with the principles and the literature on church polity are by no means promising. But where there is good will, an honest endeavor to get hold of what is right, there one may come a long way. And it is needed.

Principle no. 1 especially needs our attention. Do we all understand it? Is it too much to ask whether it is fully in accord with the Word? Is it absolutely excluded that the authors could have been mistaken? The opposition to this principle at any rate justifies the raising of such questions. Thus: questions awaiting answers, tasks awaiting solution.

One may, of course, get away from these questions and tasks by once more asserting that principle no. 1 aims at the unorganized holy catholic Church, the communion of saints. But that is precisely what it does not do.

One may indeed make objections by pointing to the exposition of principle 4, which speaks of the congregation’s outward organization. But this principle must be understood in connection

with principle no. 1.

Principle no. 1 is directed against two things. First, against the complex organizations which we call the organized church, the state churches, the denominations, and so forth. The principles regard these organizations not as church or congregation in the sense of Scripture, but as worldly organizations. Second, they are directed against the view that the communion of saints, the unorganized church, is all that is needed. For the Church in the sense of Scripture is presented by S. and D. as consisting of congregations, not individuals.

Already in 1875 S. and D. turned “the weapons ... against pietism and false spirituality, which dissolves the Christian community into isolated individuals.” “It belongs inseparably to the essence of the Christian Church to exist in the form of congregations, not as individual Christians.”

In 1895 S. and D. wrote (joint declaration): “The Church is the Kingdom of God on earth, which between Christ’s ascension and His coming in glory has no other rightful form than the congregation.”

In 1898 S. declared: “This is something new when in point 1 we declare the congregation to be the proper form of the Kingdom of God on earth; for for hundreds of years men have called the church the proper form.”

That this means something other than adopting a new name for an old thing appears from what S. wrote in 1896:

The first thing, then, which comes forward as the scriptural principle in the relation between congregation and church body is this: that the congregation is the original, and the church body the derived; the congregation is the true, proper, apostolic, and Christian form of the Kingdom of God on earth in the time from the outpouring of the Spirit until Christ’s coming again; all outward societies or churches or institutions or associations or companies have, according to God’s Word, their justification only as serving instruments for the congregation, not as authorities that govern and issue commands.

This principle is the first and most far-reaching of all rules for church polity. The individual local congregation has God’s Word over it, has Jesus Christ as head and Lord, has God’s Spirit as its guide; but it has no other authority over it.

It is entirely clear that the New Testament teaches that Christians should not only have an inward fellowship of the Spirit with one another, but that they should also form outwardly organized congregations with their officebearers and their rules.

We should depart from the altogether clear demand of God's Word if we sought to be so spiritual that we would have no outward congregation. The outward congregation belongs to apostolic and biblical Christianity. Among the many who refuse to belong to any outward congregation because it is not spiritual enough for them, some suffer from a grievous lack and weakness in their Christianity, though it is far from us to mean that such frail Christians are not Christians at all. On the other hand, the same does not hold for what is called church bodies ...

"The very first principle of the critique of church polity is therefore this, that the Christian Church consists of free, independent, and self-governing congregations ... Such is the teaching of Scripture. (Veiledning 335).

The congregational form is necessary, according to S. "The Kingdom of God has its inner essence, which is righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit. It also has its outward form, which is the congregation, the Spirit's people in the world." The congregation is this outward form, "the only outward form appointed by God for His Kingdom on earth."

But this outward form of the Kingdom of God, the congregation, itself has both an outward side and an inward side.

There is talk of "its inward side in its invisible essence," its "inner spiritual essence." According to this, in "its innermost essence it [the congregation] is the body of Jesus Christ, or the work of the Holy Spirit." "In the dogmatic sense, people are not received into the congregation by a decision of the congregational meeting—but by the Word, Baptism, and faith." (S. and D. 1895).

But the congregation also has its outward side, its mixed character, the formal organization.

It is the believers in the local congregation who are the body of Christ. The unbelieving members are members of the congregation in an improper sense; they stand only in an outward connection.

The proper form of the Kingdom is the outward congregation: "The individual outward congregation is the body of Christ ... every member in this outward congregation is a member of Christ's body" (Ofstedal in Veiledning 65). "The body of Christ ... is visible, because it is believing men and women who work with the Word and the Sacraments, and it is the outward, organized fellowship of these which is called congregation." (S. in Veiledning, 38). "What is said about the unity of all congregations is also said about the individual outward congregation." (Ofstedal in Veiledning, 65).

And again Sverdrup:

For all congregations and for every one of them Jesus Christ is the living foundation upon which the congregation is built ...

“Paul did not mean that Jesus and His life, death, and resurrection are once for all the foundation of the Church, and since it has once been laid, it cannot be laid again; rather, he means that by the preaching of the Gospel in Corinth this foundation was laid there again, and the Corinthian congregation was built upon it.

“And not that alone. All congregations, and every single one of them, are the body of Jesus Christ. In this body He is the soul, and for this body He is the head ... As intimately as the soul is joined to the body, so near is Jesus to the congregation ... He Himself is the head and governs and leads the congregation, works through it. (Luth. Kirkeblad 1893, no. 4).

... every congregation and every congregational member must remember that it is not merely the whole great Church, the gathering of all congregations, which is the body of Jesus and the bride of Jesus; rather, it is precisely the little gathering of people who in each place gather around the Word and the Sacraments that has the calling to be God’s temple, the body of the risen and glorified Savior, through which He Himself will work on earth, by which He still reveals Himself on earth.

Therefore the responsibility is so great. God’s temple is holy; therefore it is all the greater a transgression for a congregational member to be profane and thereby corrupt God’s temple.

Luther’s words about ‘the whole Christian congregation on earth’ must also be true of each individual congregation, if this truly answers to its name. (L. K. 1893, no. 10).

Some of the most unfortunate expressions theologians have been accustomed to use concerning the congregation are: visible and invisible, inward and outward. They are thoroughly confusing. S. and O. have to some degree accepted this usage, and it was scarcely to be expected that they could use these expressions for 35 years without committing one inconsistency or another—for who has not been made to stumble by these expressions? <sup>11</sup>

One should note the difference.

There may be an outward congregation even where external organization is lacking. “It is

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<sup>11</sup>In 1877 Oftedal wrote: The congregation is visible because God’s Word and the Sacraments are there, and invisible because the believers are there and it is “the body of Christ” (Kvartalskrift 1877, 15).



the use of the Word and the Sacraments that constitutes a congregation in the biblical sense”<sup>12</sup>. This means the local congregation—not “the whole Christian Church.” The outward organization, the outward congregational form, follows as a rule afterward.

Where these means [Word and Sacraments] are rightly used, there is at least a mission, and where these means work eternal life in souls, there the body of Christ and His congregation are present according to their essence, even though there is not yet any congregational organization” (S. S. II, 236).

“The congregation [the outward congregation] was there ... already at Pentecost. It had adopted no constitution, chosen no officebearers, organized itself in any way by outward regulations and decisions; nevertheless it was there.” (S. S. II, 9).

The formal organization is the external, outward organization. But the organization in reality is the congregation, the local congregation.

(N. B. We distinguish sharply between outward organization and outward congregation.)

The local congregation, when it answers to its name, is a gathering of believers. It is defined in principle no. 2, which deals precisely with the congregation’s constitutive members. This principle states what the congregation theoretically is. Those who are called constitutive members are believers. But in the outward organization there are also hypocrites; they intrude into it, they are no constituent part, their connection is only outward. That is what the congregation in its practice is according to principle no. 4, and the Augsburg Confession, art. 8. (cf. S. S. III, 368).

S. and O. laid such weight on the constituted local congregation (organization may follow later) that some may say that they made it into a sacrament. And it is true that S.’s view of the congregation resembled very much the early church’s view of the sacraments. Therefore S. could say that one who lived alone on an island had no need of the Supper, the congregation’s meal. The older theologians said that it is not the lack of the Sacraments that condemns, but contempt for them. Compare Sverdrup: “Where an individual Christian lives alone in prison or under some other compulsion, there the lack of a congregation will not lead to his perdition (Veiledning 95).” “The congregation is absolutely necessary where it is possible.” “Where Christians can be congregation and will not, there is at times great danger for their soul (95).”

“For our Free Church people, the matter stands thus: that when God’s Word has set the

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<sup>12</sup>In 1897 Sverdrup wrote: The congregation becomes visible by its believing members and their activity. ... The body of Christ ... is visible. (Veiledning 37, 38).

congregation as the proper form for the Kingdom of God on earth until Christ's coming, then it is both necessary and possible to have congregation, whatever it may cost" (against the free-free).

All this, of course, points to the "outward congregation."

The local congregation was of such significance for S. and O. that, for example, in the 1870s they did not wish any local congregation to be established at Augsburg, although their colleagues Gunnensen and Gjeldaker wished this. The matter was dealt with several times in the faculty. Even a faculty opinion was submitted. Among the grounds S. and O. advanced was this, that school discipline with its strictness would interfere disruptively with the congregation as a community of professors (and their families) and students. Church discipline and school discipline might conflict with one another.

The local congregation was of such significance for S. and O. that they never stated, so far as I know, that an individual could be a member of several congregations at once; whereas they saw nothing wrong in a congregation's standing in connection with several church bodies, since these (in contrast to the congregation) are not governed by the law of the body of Christ. The church bodies were only organs, worldly arrangements, which could serve the congregation, which was the actual organization, the divine institution, the only form in which the holy catholic church becomes manifest (cf. Pontoppidan F. C. B. edition, col. 243).

No matter how much one wishes to get away from the fact that S. and O. held this doctrine of the congregation; it is the same how much one wishes to twist their statements—one cannot get away from the concept of the local congregation as the fundamental thing in S. and O's conception of the Church. **For them the local congregation was not merely something expedient, not merely an organization necessary in an organic sense; for them it was at least just as necessary in the specifically Christian sphere as the family is in the social. One may call the whole human race a family, but the individual family is a necessary ordinance for the proper growth and upbringing of the human race.** Neither state nor school nor orphanage can wholly replace upbringing in the home. So too, all Christians together are called congregation, or church, but this whole Christian congregation or church consists of individual congregations.

## 1.7 Installment 7: “Folkebladet,” April 24, 1918

The controversy over Augsburg in the 1890s arose from disagreements about the concept of the church, disagreements that also shaped ministerial education. The view held by S. and O. differed greatly, especially from that of Dr. Schmidt, who in 1893 left Augsburg together with his colleagues, Professors Bøckman and Lund.

For Schmidt the outward congregation was of lesser significance. For him, what mattered above all was “the whole Christian congregation,” that is, the holy catholic Church. His concept of the church is found in *Luthersk Kirkeblad*, no. 41:

Christ’s true congregation is not first and foremost an outward union around certain officeholders or a certain visible organization that catches the eye, but it is the fellowship and union of true believers in the spirit, as Jesus’ true believing disciples and, each for his part, members of His spiritual body...

Thus also now, as formerly, God’s true Israel is not this or that outward flock or association of persons, a visible organization under a definite and conspicuous form of rule; rather, God’s right and genuine household are all those whom He who searches the hearts knows and loves as His own, that is, as true regenerate children of God through faith in Jesus Christ. All these true believers are members of the one body, and besides these true believers, whether they be adults or little children, there exists no member in Jesus’ body. The true and glorious unity of the Church as Jesus’ body is therefore a spiritual unity, the unity of hearts by the same spirit of faith.

Outward difference with respect to time, place, language, nation, yes, even outward ecclesiastical connection and the teaching ministry, makes no breach here in the unity of faith and spirit. All who in the wilderness of this world have learned to feel themselves bitten by the serpent, and who with the longing of faith look up to the Lamb of God, who bears the sin of the world, all these are united with Jesus by this faith that seeks salvation and are members of His body, whether moreover they be a Jew or Greek, barbarians or Scythians, whether they live in the Old or in the New Testament, whether they speak this or that tongue, yes, whether moreover they be Catholics or Protestants, or whatever kind of society they may belong to by outward confessional connection....

But if this is so, that the essential and proper unity of the Christian Church, whereby according to God’s judgment it is one single Church, is a spiritual unity, then does it perhaps follow from this that the outward and visible unity is an

altogether unessential and indifferent matter?

With respect to the answer that Dr. Schmidt gives, S. and O. found that the view of “the congregation” was lacking. And several years later Sv. wrote: “The core of the matter is this, which Dr. Schmidt has not yet touched: Are the New Testament’s statements about the congregation as binding upon Christians as its statements about what has been called doctrine?” This was in the years when Schmidt entered the lists on behalf of “the old church order.”

According to S. and O., therefore, the New Testament was normative also for church polity. According to Schmidt, it was a rule only for doctrine.

S. wrote: “And above all other principles in the Free Church there stands the decisive authority of the Word of God in the matter of the congregation and of church polity no less than in the question of doctrine” (Veiledning 93).

“We... have... enlightenment about ‘church polity’ in the Bible.” We need not “speculate out something ‘that suits the times’; there is light enough for the congregation in the New Testament, and it is not worth letting anyone persuade us that it does not suit our time” (105; cf. 33).

“The very first principle of the Free Church regarding church polity is this, that the Christian church consists of free, independent, and self-governing congregations” (35).

All this is comprised in the formal principle of Congregationalism:

“The Word of God in Scriptures is designed to furnish, and actually does furnish, the sole objective authority, not only for the doctrines, but also for the constitution, worship, and discipline, of the Christian church.” (Ladd 38).

“It is a principle of congregationalism, that the Scriptures are the only infallible guide in matters of church order and discipline.” (Punchard 19).

Or, as the Declaration of the English Congregationalists of 1833 says:

“They believe that the New Testament contains, either in the form of express statute, or in the example and practice of apostles and apostolic churches, all the articles of faith necessary to be believed, and all the principles of order and discipline requisite for constituting and governing Christian societies; and that human traditions fathers and councils, canons and creeds, possess no authority over the faith and practice of Christians.”

We now understand why S., in a newspaper discussion with Dr. Kildahl, could say: “God and His Son and His Spirit are entirely omitted from Kildahl’s consideration of church polity”

(Veiledning 159).

For S. and O. the question of church polity was a fundamental question: church polity had to be derived from Scripture just as truly as doctrine. Not so for Schmidt and Kildahl. And not so for the great majority in the Lutheran church, as is illuminated in the following citation from one of the newest works in theology. After having set forth the Catholic church's conception of divine right, the author says:

“According to the evangelical conception there is no divine right (church law). The Bible is a source only for faith, not for law. The Symbols are confessional writings, not law-books. For Luther, Christ was no ‘jurist or ruler in outward matters.’ The Lutheran confessional writings do indeed contain a series of thoughts that have become determinative for later legal formations, yet they are nevertheless not sources of law.

Somewhat otherwise it is with the Reformed church, insofar as it has seen itself occasioned to adopt the apostolic congregational order. But it too rejects the Roman juridical conception.

We have now made it clear that principle 1 is a constitutional principle: it is not a dogmatic principle. As a principle of church order, it belongs to ethics, and as applied ethics it belongs to church polity. If one wants the dogmatic side of the congregation, one can find it treated, for example, in Sverdrup's “Dogmatic paragraphs on the congregation” (S. S. VI.)

Dogmatics sets forth chiefly what God does, His work; ethics, what the human being does, his activity.

Dogmatics presents the congregation as the work of the Spirit, furnished with means of grace and gifts of grace.

Ethics presents the congregation as a gathering of people who know the conditions of salvation, proclaim the Kingdom of God, and labor for its advancement among themselves and others. Therefore it also treats the church's ministry, organization, relation to the state, tasks, and so forth.

Dogmatics presents the congregation as a gift from God; ethics presents it as a task: God's gifts become our tasks; He gives the power to carry them out, He uses us as His instruments.

Ethics also treats church polity, but more from an abstract standpoint. A parallel discipline to ethics is practical theology; it applies theological knowledge to practical life, as we live it in experience. Church polity is one of the special branches of practical theology and treats—both theoretically and practically, historically and systematically—the area peculiar

to it, which ethics, so to speak, only brushes upon.

Guiding Principles are throughout principles (or fundamental propositions) for church polity. They are principles, not a task. They do not pertain to the individual person, but to the community. They are not an ideal. They do not set forth an unrealizable demand.

Gynild indeed says: “If the same principles did not demand more than what we could carry out, then they would not be Christian.”

An astonishing statement about what Christian principles demand..

Thus perhaps Søren Kierkegaard might have spoken—the spokesman of paradox and of life-denying asceticism, he who called himself a police talent and an angel of accusation, and thought he was appointed to point out what Christianity required and to maintain that there was no one who could fulfill its demands. For K. Christianity was something so exacting that he did not profess himself to be a Christian.

Thus perhaps Bjørnstjerne Bjørnson too might have spoken, when he was working on his drama *Over Evne*, where—in another spirit than Kierkegaard’s—he sought to show that Christianity is beyond one’s power: its demands cannot be met.

But thus it ought not to be spoken where one wishes to preach evangelical Lutheran Christianity, even if one makes a principle identical with a demand or an ideal.

The highest ideals we possess come from Christianity. The ideals of the ancient world were poor; it did not take much to realize them. Its “god” could not help; for he was so infinitely far away. But the ideals of Christianity lie in the distance. Much is required to realize them. But then the Christian’s God is always near. He gives the power to realize even the highest Christian ideal.

The further away the ideals are, the more exertion is needed in order to attain them (activity). The nearer God is, the more receptivity there is for Him and His gifts (receptivity). He gives us what He requires. And the highest thing He requires is evangelical perfection (Matt. 5:48, not the perfection demanded by the Law). He gives us this perfection (Phil. 3:14, 15: “Let us then, as many as be perfect...”)

The doctrine of Scripture concerning this highest goal or ideal we also find in the Augsburg Confession, art. 27, 12:

Christian perfection consists in this: earnestly to fear God, and yet at the same time to set one’s whole confidence in Him, and on account of Christ to trust that we have a reconciled God; to pray to God for help and confidently expect it from

Him in all that, according to one's calling, one has to do; and besides this, in one's outward conduct, unweariedly to do good works and take heed to one's calling. In this consists true perfection and true worship of God.

By Christian perfection is meant neither sinlessness nor the state of being complete. But according to Scripture the predicate perfect belongs to the one who has the moral quality that God wills him to have. The Christian strives to make faith and love a settled part of his spiritual life, so that they determine what he does and what he is.

One of the great thinkers in the realm of Christian thought has said: "The highest ideal of life is Christian perfection. It is a goal that is not of the world to come, but which can be understood and realized here on earth."

It is precisely the Christian ideals that can be realized.

There is also a heavenly goal. It is not thought to be realized on earth. But it shall be realized there where it is appointed to be realized, when we "see Him as He is" and when the Son "delivers the kingdom to God the Father" (1 Cor. 15:24). There is another order there than in the Christian economy on earth, where we may say: By the grace of God I am what I am (1 Cor. 15:10); I can do all things in Christ who makes me strong. Or: by the grace of God it is possible to keep one's baptismal covenant.

He who is a Christian must fight. Luther said, "A Christian is not one who has already become one (nicht im Wordensein), but one who is becoming (im Werden) a Christian. He who is a Christian is no Christian." Or, as Chrysostom said: "To be perfect is: not to think oneself perfect." Or, as others have expressed it: "The Christian's perfection consists in this, that he is always conscious of his imperfection." The more the Christian life increases, the more one comes to know one's own imperfection; but the more one also learns to know grace, that God does not require more than He gives.

It is possible that this sounds strange to our ears, but it is nothing new—at any rate not new for a man such as, for example, Gustav Jensen, who in his book *Fra Menighedsforsamlingen* says of Matt. 5:43–48, Be ye perfect:

He (Jesus) does not hesitate to set before them the highest goal that it is possible at all to set... A father does not lay before his children what is impossible and unattainable, and when your heavenly Father wills that His children should strive after the highest, then it is because He, as Father, wills to help them attain it. Therefore we also see in the New Testament that the Lord Himself and His apostles often speak of perfection, and indeed of a perfection which already here,

according to its basic features, can be attained by His Holy Spirit... Be grasped by Christ, and then be among those who strive after it... And you shall surely advance in that perfection which can be attained here on earth under the grace of the forgiveness of sins, and when the time comes, win the prize.

This therefore applies to an ideal, a goal (S. would presumably say: a principle) which Jesus Himself has set forth as “the highest goal that it is possible at all to set.” Leading Lutheran men proclaim that it is attainable here on earth. But then Gynild comes and proclaims that Guiding Principles (which are not at all ideals of life and which were, moreover, written by sons of the nineteenth century) are Christian in so high a degree that they demand more than we can carry out: “If the same principles did not demand more than what we could carry out, then they would not be Christian.”

If some solitary schoolmaster had concocted something of that sort, I should have remained silent. But when a pastor, who time and again has been chairman of the Free Church, publishes something like this, then it is right to go against such an assertion.

Guiding Principles are not demands, are not ideals. They are principles.

What is a principle?

The word principle is used in very different senses. In philosophy—which, to use a Gynildian word, the “learned fools” must now and then condescend to concern themselves a little with—principle means: highest concept, supreme proposition, law, axiom, explanatory ground, point of departure. A favorite definition of philosophy is the science of principles.

In the science of religion, principle means the conception of the fundamental impulse or fundamental power that lies behind the individual psychological expressions of life and facts.

In historical psychology, “principle” is applied to a totality determined by certain interests, for example in the analysis of an individual, the character of a people, a section of culture. Here principle can be paraphrased by words such as national spirit, spirit of the age, essence, fundamental view, fundamental idea, idea, and so forth.

The psychological conception of religion sees in “principle” not ready-made propositions, but a fundamental disposition of the soul: the principle is the point of unity behind consciousness.



## 1.8 Installment 8: “Folkebladet,” May 01, 1918

A principle is commonly a foundational proposition. It means beginning, and it is applied to the first propositions or chief rules which one follows within a given domain. It is “that ground with whose validity the rest stands or falls.”

It is, in other words, the unity of the way from which a multiplicity of expressions of life are derived and explained, an original unity to which thought may be led back. As such it may be what, in a foreign term, one calls a “goal of striving.” But in the first line, and essentially, it is a resting-point, fertilizing seed for the whole generation of thought, a point of support, an explanatory ground for the whole of the powers of development in, and a foundation for, the moral, religious, material, personal, and social life.

A Christian principle is not beyond one’s strength. It is a foundation upon which to stand, something that supports, that bears. Therefore Sverdrup could write—and it was among the last things he wrote (see facsimile in S. S. III.)—“A false principle is like a failing foundation.”

Dogmatics has its principles. They are treated in what is called the doctrine of principles in dogmatics, or fundamental doctrine, which constitutes almost a third of this discipline (for example, Kirms’s, v. Oettingen’s). Lønning’s little doctrine of faith, which in my school days was used at Augsburg, contained no doctrine of principles, for which reason nothing further was said about it in “class.”

Ethics also has its principles. They are found in the doctrine of principles in ethics, which likewise constitutes about a third of the discipline of ethics. Since nothing in this discipline was taught at Augsburg, nothing further was said there about the principles of ethics either.

Church polity also has certain principles which are derived from a fundamental principle. The principles of church polity were not discussed to any extent in “class.” Instruction in this area came theoretically chiefly through the newspapers, and practically through the church conflict.

Thus: three groups of principles.

1. What are the dogmatic principles? One speaks of two great Reformation principles, which at the same time are the chief foundational propositions for all Protestant dogmatic thought: the formal principle and the material principle, first set forth by Twesten in 1829.

The formal principle is the foundational proposition concerning Scripture as the sole decisive norm of Christianity. It is the epistemological point of departure, the source to which we must go. It is the principle of Scripture.

The material principle is the foundational proposition concerning justification by faith alone. It is the religious principle for a dogmatic evaluation of Christianity. It may also be designated as the Kingdom of God, a revealed act of divine grace, realized in Christ's righteousness.

Dogmatics has to do with knowledge. On the one hand, it has a direction and an aim. On the other hand, it has a regulative principle, something that guides. The Danish dogmatician T. R. Vang says that "the direction and goal of Paul's knowledge" are "God's thoughts concerning human beings, the content of his will, his plan of salvation and its fulfillment." And then he asks: "But what now is the principle that guides him in this his energetic thinking?" "He has expressed it in the words that return again and again: in Christ."

2. If one asks: What is the principle of ethics? then the answers differ. In ancient ethics it was pride. In Abelard's ethics (the Middle Ages) it was conscience. Reinhard (ca. 1800) held that the principle of ethics was love (against Kant's principle, pure morality). Goethe said: "I bow before him (Christ) as the divine revelation of the highest principle of morality," but in Goethe's eyes Christianity was surely only a revelation of natural religion. He also wanted to worship the sun, "for it is likewise a revelation of the highest!" De Wette made faith the principle of moral teaching, Harleß regeneration, Darwin evolution.

According to J. T. Beck, the principle of ethics is "Christ living and working in us through the Word." Gisle Johnson: "The Christian faith, as it shows itself working through love." Luthardt: "Communion with God in Christ, which in faith becomes a personal reality, and in life shows itself working in love." N. Seeberg: "Humanity's living communion with God in order to serve God with a view to the aim of the eternal ideal." Grützmacher: "The source and principle of theological ethics is the Christian character." Oftedal, Gunneren, and Sverdrup: "Christ's liberating power in a Christian life of personality."

3. If we were to seek a highest principle for polity, a fundamental thought from which, for example, Living Principles is derived, then it would have to be the universal priesthood, which Kahnis regarded as the third principle in the Reformation. But whereas Kahnis called it the Church principle and applied it to the invisible Church, S. and O. applied it to the visible body of Christ, the congregation, and called it the congregational principle.

Living Principles are foundational propositions for church polity derived from one of the chief principles of the Reformation, the universal priesthood.

It is to be regretted that S. and O. did not have time to give expression to their principles in a rounded, concluding work. With such a work they could have made—for the time being—a contribution in practical theology which they could scarcely have made by any other work. In the area of polity they represented, for more than a generation—and with all

diligence—a direction which must be described as new within Lutheran theology. Here their plus was greater than it was in dogmatics, exegesis, or history. Sverdrup was a gifted teacher in dogmatics, and he was well at home in the Old Testament. But did he represent any new direction in these disciplines? If so, wherein did it consist? Oftedal had wide-ranging interests, but did he represent any new direction in New Testament exegesis or in church history? In these areas, compared with the field of polity, they were essentially eclectics.

I do not say that this was less important than that which they contributed to polity. But in the history of theology, in the area of the concept of the Church, their illumination of church polity will stand as their distinct contribution. Even the little that has been included in “Veiledning” can, in its significance, be placed on a par with Höfling’s well-known work, *Fundamental Propositions for Evangelical Lutheran Church Polity* (year 1850, 225 pages, 3 editions in two years, also translated into Norwegian). Höfling’s book was accorded the predicates “epoch-making,” “of enduring significance.” It is not too much to say that the contribution of S. and O. (even in *Veiledning*) just as fully deserves the same predicates. In several respects the contribution of S. and O. signifies a great advance.

Höfling’s book ought to be able to contribute a little toward setting some “Doubting Thomas” among us on the right track, since it both says and proves that church polity goes deeper than merely external forms and various trifles, about which those who know least of the discipline never grow tired of talking. In the preface Höfling says:

“It is not single forms of Evangelical-Lutheran church polity, but properly its principles and foundational propositions, concerning which in our day, alongside great confusion, there prevails a great difference of opinion, and concerning which in various places a controversy has arisen that threatens to become serious and could even give rise to a lamentable schism, if it should continue to be conducted in the same manner as hitherto and if it should not succeed in being settled by way of persuasion. A manifestly Catholicizing hierarchical fundamental view seeks to assert itself within the sphere of our Church, even if not as exclusively legitimate, then at any rate first of all as co-legitimate, in that it supposes itself to display a quite particular fidelity to the Church and its confession. The less now the author can regard the important meaning of our confession, or the true consequences of our Church principle with respect to this point, as doubtful, the more must he, in the interest of that Church and that confession to which he belongs with all his heart, feel himself called to reiteration and contradiction. And his highest wish is now that he may be so fortunate as to set forth the distinctive principles and foundational propositions of Evangelical-Lutheran church polity in a manner convincing to all. When he believes that he gives here one thing or another that is new, this applies not so much to practical results as to principal understanding, development,

arrangement, and grounding. . . ”

So much for Höfling.

Höfling represents the low-church standpoint in the ecclesiastical controversy in Germany around 1850. The leaders of the high-church party who attacked him were men such as Stahl, Löhe, Lechler, Huschke, Kliefoth, Dieckhoff, Münchmeyer—well-known names in church history. These men laid great weight on the Church’s legal determinations, regarded the ministry as a divine institution, and held semi-Catholic notions concerning the administration of the sacraments, ordination, and so forth (Lønning became their faithful disciple).

Höfling’s writing became a liberating word. The tendency he combated suffered a great defeat. There are now exceedingly few in the Lutheran lands of Europe who represent this tendency. The heirs came to America. Here the tendency has become a major power.

## 1.9 Installment 9: “Folkebladet” May 08, 1918

Among us too there have been controversies, yes, schisms. Among us too words have been spoken that wear and wound. But over these words there reigns great disagreement, and there may come new schisms. These can be prevented—not by resorting to threats or the language of power, not by empty plotting or compromises—but by going the way of conviction. If there is agreement as to what the principles are and what they intend, then much will have been gained. It may be another question to decide whether the principles stand wholly and entirely on the ground of Scripture. First there must be agreement on what the thing is, before there can be discussion of its “how.”

That seeking to promote this understanding—and both Birkeland and I have sought it—has nothing to do with person and personal wrangling, is plain. It is small-minded thinking that writes, for example, Birkeland’s articles to the account of personal squabbling. Birkeland’s contributions have not concerned anything lying between persons, but something lying outside them, namely what the principles are and what they mean.

Peace comes with understanding. But it can also come in another way. It is possible to bury the principles and get a peace that is as silent as the grave’s. In the graveyard it is hushed and still: the silence of death. There one contends neither over personal issues nor over principles.

If the Free Church buries the principles—or whatever still remains of them—this will not, without more, mean the Free Church’s downfall. It can surely continue its existence, taking comfort in memories from former days, lowering its aim and writing “the enlivening and liberation of the individuals” instead of “the enlivening and liberation of the congregations.” But then it must also prepare itself to find an answer to the question: Why does S stand alone?

But even if the principles are allowed for some time yet to exist upon the surface of the earth, there is nevertheless danger that they may become a petrification, or a common platform from which everyone fetches what best suits his own need, whether it be a new Christian type, or an ideal, or something else.

Therefore: the way of conviction.

If the understanding of the principles were greater, the annual meetings would look different. As things now are, they are a kind of adding machine for the politics that are carried on between the annual meetings, an emergency brake to which the train staff resort every time they “see ghosts” on the line. So it was in Marinette, in Willmar, and in Fargo, where

arrangements were even made to put some inconvenient passengers off. Had the understanding of the principles been greater, the meeting in Fargo would not have witnessed that concerted, peevish opposition to Birkeland and me. The meeting in Fargo was a classic expression of the situation among us.

Birkeland's and my articles in *Folkebladet* took principle no. 2 as their point of departure. And this principle is, after all, acknowledged as essentially correct—even in the most conservative Lutheran circles in Europe. What our articles asserted were old Lutheran truths concerning the religious equality of the laity with the pastors. No attempt was made to overturn formal rights and arrangements, which were valued for precisely what they are—human arrangements.

I showed myself fully in agreement with Scripture and Lutheran doctrine and paid due regard to the principles. No one has refuted anything that B. and I wrote. The opponent's weapons and shield were vaporous declamations about “spirit,” personalities, and “periphery.” Nothing tangible. Yet the loudest spokesmen against the ordination articles were certainly not the faithful followers in church law of the Coast pastor (J. J. Jansen), who himself also gives a detailed account of the problems of ordination. Jansen wrote—as we have earlier indicated—in his autobiography:

“Together with my aunts and my dreams of becoming a pastor, there had developed in me a sort of high-church enthusiasm for the church and the office, and with that also an intense interest in the literature as a whole. It was here that I meant to study, understand, and come to a result, first concerning what the New Testament teaches regarding the office. I read Ritschl, A. Rothe, Thiersch, Stahl, Löhe, Lechler, but on the other side also Höfling, Richter, Rudelbach. I studied Carpzov, Böhmer, Buseudorf, and many more. The great folios in my library still remind me of many an eager hour.....

“My heart was from the beginning with Stahl and Löhe, with the high-church, catholicizing, mystical doctrine of the church and doctrine of office. But in the course of study I became more and more low-church. How did I become low-church? The New Testament compelled me. Thus there came forth my, no doubt very imperfect, scientific attempt, ‘The Ecclesiastical Office in the Apostolic Age.’ (1877–78).”

It should be known that Jakob Sverdrup attacked this attempt in *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*. It was too high-church for Jakob Sverdrup, who himself wrote much about the office—low-churchly. But more low-church than Jakob Sverdrup was his brother Georg, who with respect to the office essentially shared Sohm's view.

But when this low-church doctrine of office, with the corresponding contentious understanding

of ordination, came forward again in *Folkebladet*, 1917, it seemed to some like something uncannily foreign and free-churchish. Our contributions were even perceived as personal attacks.

Birkeland's and my articles were lumped together at the Fargo meeting. What the dissatisfied said about the one of us was also made to apply to the other. A remarkable, artificially constructed relation of solidarity! As for "personalities," I knew myself quite free of them. And as regards Birkeland, it astonishes me that he could write as objectively as he did, after the unjust treatment given him in Willmar, and after the maneuvering that had been employed, and had succeeded, in preventing his reelection as chair of Augsburg's Board of Trustees. It was said that money would not come in to Augsburg if he were to retain the chairman's seat, and that confidence in the school would disappear! Even the ordination committees had brought Birkeland's name into the questions they put to the theological candidates. In view of this and much else I say: all respect for Birkeland.

As for me, I have always sought to argue as one generally argues in respectable theological journals. It has been objective truth that has concerned me. When I have said or shown that this or that publicly advanced assertion is untenable, then I have said no more than a conscientious carpenter has the right and duty to say to another carpenter: This beam will not do. Get something else! But such an address is no personal attack. Nor is it murder—which, as I understand it, an editorial statement would underline. It is not for murder's sake that holes are shot in untenable arguments. Coverings that serve to protect what is false—it is all one how well-intentioned they may be—deserve to be leveled.

My language has been the non-narcotizing language of duty. Such language speaks openly. It does not whisper, does not threaten. It does not whisper in the twilight, does not compose protests and does not circulate petitions. It does not maneuver under cover of committee chairmen's reports. In its embarrassment it does not take refuge in words like "spirit and life," words which in Scripture mean very much, but which here and there among us have in fact been degraded into a slogan that conceals kinds of diversity of many sorts, including intellectual irrationality and sloth.

The non-narcotizing language of duty has also been Birkeland's language, yes, even where he cited Stendal's words about Christ and Belial. For there are indeed collisions among us. And if one takes into consideration that the men who most often use the grand language about spirit and life took two days of the Fargo meeting's costly time to discuss Birkeland's (and my) contributions, then one gets the impression that the collisions are anything but child's play. Yes, it seems as though there were a little (perhaps much) of a Christ-Belial

relation of opposition here, where Birkeland and I become a kind of establishments of Belial in modern form, trafficking in personalities and needing publicly to be chastised and instructed concerning the necessity of the one thing needful, exactly as though we had never before heard or known what the first foundational truths of Christianity are.

I have always respected Birkeland for his labors on behalf of the principles. He is one of the few who has shown a firm grasp of the principles and has interpreted them consistently. If there is anything to object to in the consequences B. has set forth, then the fault is not Birkeland's, but the principles'.

Now when Folkebladet has undertaken to humiliate Birkeland by editorial rebukes—boldly personal rebukes—and by publishing others' disapproving criticism of his person without any sort of editorial dissent, it seems to me that he has good ground to take issue with Folkebladet, even if he sets aside the personal element in these articles and fastens upon the more substantive side.

1. Birkeland had good reason to criticize the decision that the Fargo meeting adopted in connection with the union matter. Neither the decision—which came as an overruling—nor the editorial defense, which was surely prepared in calm and ease, is in harmony with Leading Principles.

2. Birkeland also had good reason to criticize the editorial "Impressions from the annual meeting." I must say I did not recognize the annual meeting in these impressions; nor did I know with what justification the editorial office expressed its hope that "those who hereafter write in the paper will respect the general sentiment among the people with regard to this matter." But I did recognize the annual meeting in the criticism that P. Fostervold exercised upon the "Impressions." Fostervold wrote among other things this:

"But how the paper can write such things is more than I can understand. When one tries to make it appear that the general sentiment among the people was on the side of those pastors who attacked the articles on ordination, then Folkebladet must know that it is doing the annual meeting an injustice. For every single layman who spoke in this matter—and they were not so few—placed himself clearly and decidedly against these pastors. And they surely, better than anyone else, represented the general sentiment among the common people. These men were not, either, some young brawlers. They were older, sober-minded men. There were, moreover, several pastors as well who wholly took the laity's side in this matter. Besides, it was in the votes that the strongest words were spoken, and it was these that showed the general sentiment among the people in the meeting."

So far as I was able to survey the situation at the annual meeting, two thirds of the meeting's



voting members cast their decisive votes on Birkeland's side. The laity for a time thought of holding their own meeting and protesting against the dissatisfied pastors' way of proceeding. But nothing came of it: they saw that it was unnecessary.

The chairman cast some light on the situation when, in characteristic fashion, he explained that the writings in *Folkebladet* (B.'s and mine) had widened the gulf between the pastors and the laity.

Unfortunately—there was indeed a gulf. It had come into being in former times. But a new element had been added: by these articles the people had, more than ever before, become conscious of this gulf. The gulf had been created long before—by the high-church doctrine of office, by the conception of the pastor's special religious standing by virtue of call and ordination. For it was no secret that at a pastors' meeting in Minneapolis it had been declared that a pastor stands in a nearer relation to God than a layman does.

## 1.10 Installment 10: “Folkebladet” May 15, 1918

It is remarkable that there are not a few in the Free Church who still adhere to neo-Lutheranism’s concept of the Church, as it was maintained by the once powerful theological faculty in Lund, Sweden—by such men as Professors Flensburg, Reuterdaahl, Sundberg, Billing. In contrast to what Sverdrup taught in “Dogmatiske paragrafer” (S. S. VI), the Lund professors maintained that “the administration of the means of grace is not a product of the congregation’s life of faith, but rather its source; it is the Lord’s own institution. The Lord has not only ordered their function, but together with them an office for their administration, and the one who has not received this office by the ordered way has no right to administer the means of grace. If he does so, he breaks not only a human, but a divine order.”

Is it “the irony of fate” that this—the so-called “Lundensian church-concept,” over which there has been so much strife in Sweden, and which a portion of the Swedish Augustana Synod bequeathed to the Conference—still is upheld in the Free Church, whose principle no. 2 is to a great extent a negation of Lund theology’s concept of the Church?

Principle no. 2—that was the core of Birkeland’s articles and mine. These articles emphasized the religious (not formal) equality of the laity with the pastors, grounded in the principle of the universal priesthood. For most laypeople this was self-evident. But for a portion of the pastors it made their heads spin. The Board of Home Missions lost its head to such a degree that it connected a young pastor’s “fall” with these articles and with their authors’ influence upon the students at Augsburg. A half-secret meeting of several pastors—local and out-of-town—had been held in Minneapolis in order to go after the ordination articles, and naturally their authors, from the rear. The result was a declaration that was read before the meeting in Fargo. It served the reactionaries’ cause, was spiritless, and received the ambiguous superscription: it had “done its work.” A pity it did not get to stand in the annual report as a worthy, enduring salt.\*)

But to what end is it to contend over who it was that won? It is of very little significance to establish who the victors were. He who stands in accord with the truth is the victor, even if outwardly he suffers defeat. With that both parties may comfort themselves. For my own part I will say that no annual meeting decision can nullify the truth in these articles, which were both biblical and Lutheran.

These articles combated the neo-Lutheran, Romanizing concept of office, which the new direction had always combated. Among other things, they showed indirectly that the annual meetings in Brainerd and Marinette had fumbled in regard to ordination. And directly they reproduced the genuinely Lutheran doctrine, which has never been foreign to Augsburg.

For in 1895 Sverdrup wrote that ordination was not “a priestly matter,” not “an act of the gathered priesthood, but a Christian act, which can be performed by any congregation” (Veiledning 27); that it was “a congregational act, which only for reasons of expediency is carried out by several congregations in common” (25).

Evidently not very many at the annual meeting in Marinette were aware of these statements, where it was said that at Augsburg a new doctrine of ordination was being advanced. Evidently the officiant at the annual meeting in Brainerd regarded ordination as a priestly matter, since he set aside two laymen (whom the meeting had elected to assist the officiant and a couple of other pastors) and on his own authority appointed two pastors to function in their place. Evidently one is still in confusion. A layman recently asked whether ordination would lose anything of its force if several laypeople were to take part in the laying on of hands. The answer he received was that Sverdrup, to be sure, was a layman, but he was never present in ordaining anyone. Thus: what S. did or did not do was to be determinative for ecclesiastical practice in generations to come!

With respect to the laying on of hands itself—well, it was not misconstrued in our articles. Our view of it was by no means foreign to Augsburg. As early as 1875 Sverdrup felt prompted to write the following, supported by Richard Rothe’s work, “Die Anfänge der chr. Kirche und ihrer Verfassung,” 160f. (S. has underlined important places in this work concerning polity):

“Not a single ordination in our sense of the word is the laying on of hands in the apostolic Church, as clearly appears from Acts 8:17, where the laying on of hands accompanies the prayer over all the baptized, that they might receive the Holy Spirit—from Acts 13:3, where the congregation in Antioch prays with laying on of hands for Paul and Barnabas, who are sent out to the work of missions, after they have already long preached the word—and from 1 Tim. 4:14 and 2 Tim. 1:6, according to which it is at any rate highly probable that Timothy twice received laying on of hands without its ever being said that by this he received any power of office. In the same way we also understand the laying on of hands here, where there is mention of the overseers of the poor, as a special direction of the intercession toward the individual.” (Samlede Skrifter I, 92).

\*) On Professor Helland’s proposal it had been decided that the declaration should be printed in the annual report. I signed the proposal (several did). It was adopted. At a later session two pastors proposed “that this decision be reconsidered, and that it be recommended to the signatories that they permit this to take place. We ground this on the fact that this resolution has already done its work...”

This proposal was not in order, insofar as it recommended to the signatories (Pastor Caspersen,

etc.) that they grant permission for reconsideration. The declaration was, after all, the property of the meeting. It could dispose of the property as it wished, without asking any of the signatories' advice. The comic thing was that a couple of the signatories, at the chairman's inquiry, rose and gave their "permission." Did the chairman lose his bearings, or the movers, or the signatories—or all of them? A peculiar parliamentarian, very considerate besides.

Even the great German stiffly orthodox Missouri Synod, on which the Free Church has not lavished many words of praise, is so free that it teaches:

"It is the call of the congregation that constitutes ministers, and actually confers the ministerial office. Ordination is not a divine ordinance, but an apostolic-ecclesiastical institution. It does not confer the ministry, as Papists and Romanizing Protestants assert, but it is only a public testimony and confirmation of the call. Ordination is not essential to the validity of the ministerial office."

I do not know what the editor teaches about ordination, but I think the annual meeting got the understanding that he would not agree that Augsburg had the view of ordination that B. and I had maintained.

3. Birkeland also has, it seems to me, good reason to place himself both questioningly and critically over against the editorial article "Church and the Churches," an extract from the Lutheran's reproduction of Dr. H. E. Jacobs's article in "Constructive Quarterly."

For many years I have known Jacobs's concept of the Church. It is that of the General Council, concerning which in the East there has been strife for more than fifty years and of whose principle Østedal wrote: it "is very far from Augsburg's." I was therefore painfully surprised when I saw Folkebladet's editorial article "Church and the Churches," and most of all when I read the editorial board's assent to the quotations from Jacobs: "What is said here, we assent to with our whole heart in the Lutheran Free Church."

No one can write thus who knows Jacobs, and who in more than a merely formal sense is in agreement with the Guiding Principles.

For with Dr. Jacobs doctrine is decisive in the church question. It is determinative for the boundaries of the confessional church and the particular church. The question of organization is for Jacobs merely and simply a question of expediency. The local congregation is to him no more divine than a church body; it is not the Kingdom's proper form, for the Kingdom of God has many forms. Jacobs is also an eager spokesman for what we call "point 3." He believes in the divine institution of the office, and finds the representative system

in the New Testament. It was Jacobs's view of the particular church that prevented the English Lutheran General Synod (1,400 pastors) from getting a seat in the proposed general Lutheran conference in Philadelphia, because it (the Synod) did not accept the whole Book of Concord! I have written a couple of pamphlets in English about this. It takes a great deal of imagination to make Jacobs's concept of the Church harmonize with the Free Church's. And nevertheless—the editorial board assents “with its whole heart” to the Lutheran's extract of Jacobs's article. I suppose the editorial board intended by its article “The Church and the Churches” to emphasize the whole Christian congregation—and that may be needed. But the whole Christian congregation, according to the Augsburg principle, exists only in the form of individual congregations, not as individuals. And this emphasis on the whole Christian congregation becomes nothing other than what Dr. Schmidt emphasized, and which called forth S. and O.'s disapproval. In the light of this, and of what we have maintained concerning the principles, and of much else that we have not expressly cited—for example S. S. II, 222 and Veiledning 36–38—we see how difficult it is for the editorial board to steer by principle no. 1. We will see it even more if, for example, we should adopt the definition of the Church given by the late missionary pastor and professor Johs. Johnson.

In a lecture, 1915, Johnson says: “The Church is the common name for all the activity that the name of Jesus releases. From the most stiff-legged institution to the most unchurchly private endeavor to make God the center of human life.” An appealing definition—but very far from the one that “stands in harmony with Augsburg's past.”

With these things before our eyes—and I could mention many others—it seems to me that Birkeland, who has been almost iron-consistent in his interpretation of the principles, has reason to ask, Is Folkebladet against Augsburg? By this question he has hardly meant to say that the one who thinks otherwise than the principles thinks unbiblically. But he has certainly meant to establish that only one authentic interpretation of the principles is possible, and that this interpretation in recent times has received headwind rather than fair wind in Folkebladet's editorial articles.

By “Augsburg” B. must surely mean the old teachers who framed the principles. For now, it is evidently very different with the interpretation of the principles at Augsburg. Some think that principle no. 1 concerns the local congregation. Some teach that it concerns the holy catholic Church. And some perhaps take the golden middle way and think that it concerns both.

The same difference of opinion meets us also among the pastors.

What applies to the different interpretations of principle no. 1 can also apply to the

other principles. One solemnly professes them, and yet has different interpretations of them. But only one interpretation can be the right one. Now, according to the editorial board, the laity has “the right and call to interpret the Word of God,” and therefore they should have the right and indeed ought to have access to express themselves concerning the principles—in Folkebladet. The editorial board understands Birkeland’s interpretation and mine as dictatorship and absolutism—and wishes to hear from the laity. But:

The editorial board heard from the laity at the last annual meeting, but did not hear well enough—so thought Fostervold.

With respect to the right and the call, it must be so that the right is conditioned by the call, and the call by the gift of grace. But is the gift of grace that enables one to interpret the Guiding Principles the possession of all? Might it not be that those who have shown that they possess something of this gift are more qualified for this interpretation than those who have displayed only a superficial acquaintance with them?

If the principles are an intellectual deduction from the Word, then surely those who have thought most about them and have applied themselves most to understand them in the light of Scripture and church-historical development must be the more entitled to interpret them.

Now everyone does indeed have the right to have his opinion about the principles. Birkeland has it. The editorial board has it. A fourteen-year-old confirmand has it too. But I will not say that the fourteen-year-old has a call and therefore the right to write in Folkebladet about Guiding Principles as, for example, Birkeland and the editorial board do. Something does depend upon the regenerate personality—and that is true. But it depends likewise upon maturity, wide reading, and much else besides. Or has the twentieth century done away with the difference in gifts of grace?

With respect to B. and the editorial board, it seems to me that B. has furnished quite different and much more reassuring guarantees for the understanding of the principles than the editorial board has done. To be sure, the editorial board has been professor and student at Augsburg for more than a generation of man. I mention this because the editorial board ascribes to seniority and locality a certain special value. But Birkeland, for his part, is not without redeeming qualifications.

Birkeland too, after all, has been at Augsburg—but likewise out on the wide expanses—both here in this country and in distant lands. He has kept his eyes open, reaped profit from his association with many church-historically significant personalities also outside Augsburg’s narrow walls. He has read much ecclesiastical literature and produced much that entitles him to be heard in the ecclesiastical sphere at least as much as any of his opponents. There

is path and originality in what he writes. No compromise-making. No foggy speech. But straight-lined thoughts and a firm grasp. With respect to the interpretation of the principles, he has had both surely and steadily pointed in the right direction. If he has at times shot beyond the mark—and who does not do that?—he has nevertheless held the direction.

But now the editorial board has taken Birkeland to school. And me as well. And those poor “learned works” on polity, which are to yield place to the unschooled layman’s judgment! How this reminds one of that colleague of Luther who left his professorship in Wittenberg, took his Bible to the unlearned peasants, and asked them to interpret it for him, since he thought that theological learning was a hindrance to the Spirit! Flattering for the peasants, but the purest fanaticism for Luther, who was not dualistic in his conception of Christianity.

It is precisely for men like the editor that I have again and again referred to the literature of polity, history’s commentary on Scripture’s doctrine of the universal priesthood, the foundation of the Guiding Principles. There lies documented in this literature the thinking and experience of many generations, from which the editorial board takes a lofty distance, and of which his writing betrays so little knowledge.

There are many who understand the Guiding Principles without having specialized in polity literature. Laypeople especially, Norwegian academics as well. But how difficult it proves for a portion of the Augsburg men to understand them! Is it because Augsburg has not been able to give them enough light, or does the fault lie in themselves?

## 1.11 Installment 11: “Folkebladet” May 22, 1918

I do not find that the editorial office fully adheres to the view of the Leading Principles held by their authors. The editor’s earlier reply to Birkeland and his two most recent editorial articles, “The Congregation,” show no change in his understanding of the principles—nor any understanding of what I have been striving to show. To be sure, he states that we are agreed on three or four points. But this agreement is, at the very most, an agreement in a formal, not in a real, sense. The editor’s concession that the principles are “essentially constitution” means, for the conclusions he draws, no more than if he had written: the principles are “essentially water.” The same I would say of the points 1 and 2 which he sets forth: they are immaterial to the consequences the editor deduces. The fourth point—“The church’s principal task is nevertheless not to labor for constitution, but for the salvation of souls, for spirit and life”—with this, however, I am heartily in agreement. For that is, or ought to be, the self-evident principal task of all congregations, churches, and church bodies, indeed of every single man and woman who is called by Christ’s name.

Otherwise I see no principal agreement in our understanding of the principles. The editorial office’s understanding of principles no. 1 and 2 is not in harmony with what I have cited from S. and D. on pages 251 and 301 of *Folkebladet* (second column) and in many other places. Sverdrup never taught that where there is one believing man, there the congregation is present “according to its essence.” Two Christians in one place are—indisputably—not a congregation, either according to essence or according to form. But if they come together around the Word and the Sacraments in order to help one another, then they are a congregation according to the essence; and if they organize the outward congregational organization, then they are a congregation also according to the form. That was Sverdrup’s doctrine and that is the doctrine of the principles.

The editor confuses the inward essence of the kingdom (righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit) with the essence of the congregation (the body of Jesus manifested in the world). And he confuses the outward form of the kingdom (the congregation) with the form of the congregation (the outward organization).

In 1875 the faculty contended (to use its own words) “against pietism and false spirituality, which dissolves Christian society into isolated individuals.” It contended for what it regarded as truth, that “it belongs essentially to the essence of the Christian church to exist in the form of congregations, not as individual Christians standing alone.” There is nothing to indicate that the editor has ever understood this language, the main principle in the Augustana understanding of the congregation. Had he done so, then he would have understood both the



principles and their authors, both Birkeland and the spirit at the Fargo meeting, better than he now does; nor would he have voted with Dr. Jacobs as he has done.

Now Prof. Nydahl has the right to hold his opinion. No one can challenge him for that. And he has the right to criticize the principles—under his own name. But the matter becomes somewhat different when he gives editorial interpretations of the principles that are interpretations away from them, and when he puts the brakes on Birkeland's writings and labels them under dictatorship, absolutism, and so forth.

For nine years now I have been a theological teacher at Augsburg, where the theological faculty has charged me with lecturing on various theological subjects—church polity as well. I have felt it to be a duty to teach in accordance with the Leading Principles. It is possible that I do not possess the qualifications to teach this subject, and that the editorial office has been aware of that through all these years. There can now no longer be any doubt that the editorial office thinks it could be done better, and that there are those at Augsburg who could do it better. I hope that the proper persons concerned will go to the proper authority and bring about a better arrangement. What I wish to make clear is that I share Birkeland's interpretation of the principles, but not that of the editorial office.

In maintaining my position in my teaching I have gone both to Scripture and to the literature on polity and to much else besides, in order to illuminate the individual principles. I know their strength and their weakness. About their weakness I have kept silent. But I have always interpreted them as I believe their authors intended them. Of the complete conformity of the principles to Scripture and of their absolute validity I have never made any assertion.

In my contributions to the paper I have both in season and out of season cited S. and D.—not in order to prove the conformity of the principles to Scripture (for that I do not need the help of others), but to show that in my understanding and interpretation of the principles I have been faithful to the authors. I have not misrepresented them. "Scripture interprets Scripture; author interprets author;" therefore I also published the little collection called "Guidance," which has been a guide both to me and to many students, and which could have been the same to the editorial office.

If in these years I have not been able to interpret the principles rightly, then I have never deserved to lecture on theology or to teach anything whatever. If I am so spiritually blind, so scientifically unfit, indeed so intellectually incapable, that through all this time I have been unable to provide a correct diagnosis of the principles, then that is a sorrowful commentary on the annual meetings' filling of professorships, and an even more sorrowful commentary on our whole higher educational system, both domestic and foreign; for I have, after all, tested a

little of both.

I mentioned something about the weakness of the principles. It can be risky to suggest anything of that sort; it can be taken as though the disciple would be above the master. But one must reckon with imperfections in masters also. I shall illustrate this. In Sweden there was carried on for more than a generation a sharp conflict between the theological faculty in Lund and the theological faculty in Uppsala. It concerned the concept of the church. We have mentioned a little about it before.

The church-concept of the Lund faculty was high-church; the means of grace constituted the church, the office was given in and with the means of grace, which were thus regarded as instituted by God; the congregation, the believers, were a product of the means of grace and the office.

The church-concept of the Uppsala faculty was low-church: the means of grace were a product of the believing congregation, the office likewise; the congregation chose a man for the office, but the holder of the office was to be a man with a gift of grace.

A massive literature was the result of the collisions between these two concepts of the church. Each of the two theological camps developed and fortified its own concept of the church and pointed out the weaknesses in the concept embraced by the opponent. Able men, far more isolated on the academic field than the students and professors at the Scandinavian-American schools, shook themselves out again and again for attack and defense. And now? Now the dust has settled. It has been shown that neither of these concepts of the church could stand. In each of them there was a hidden dualism.

Is there any dualism in the Leading Principles? If we are like the sort of Americans of whom it is said, The American cares only for the acts of the apostles, and the acts of his grandfather,—then we shall not want to know of any such question. If we are Augustanas in such a way that we care only for the acts of the apostles and the acts of Sverdrup and Oftedal—that is, care little about history and the continuity of history—then it is daring to raise such a question in our midst.

But let anyone take up Luther, Sohm, W. Walther, and he cannot avoid this question. And if he finds the answer—may he be allowed to state it? When it is so difficult to be permitted to express one's agreement with the principles, as Birkeland does, how much more difficult will it not be to document a possible disagreement? The times to come must answer that.

The principles have their significance. But they are not what is central in Christianity. And neither B. nor I have made them that. To be sure, it may look as though they were the

central thing, if one is to judge from all the column-space they have received from B. and me, especially from me. Yet they have always occupied much space in Folkebladet, even before I began to write. Still, this I will emphasize: the Free Church's Leading Principles "lay the chief weight upon the congregation and its spirit, life, and freedom." For those who think that constitutional principles concern only outward arrangements, this sentence, taken from Guidance 118, ought to be shown a measure of serious reflection. Individual ethics aims at the individual's spirit, life, and freedom. Polity aims at the congregation's spirit, life, and freedom, although—what of course no one will deny—the former is a condition for the latter. But the principles intend more than this condition: they intend a congregational life brought forth by the Spirit and lived in freedom.

One may be saved without knowing the principles. But, as said, they have their significance, but only as a means to an end, which also holds true of the organized church, great or small, of the office, of the public service of worship including preaching and hymn-singing, of the confessional writings, yes, also of Augsburg Seminary, which one has not—rhetorically at least—placed in the periphery, but has outright made into "the Free Church's heart."

Compared with Christ, who is what is central in Christianity, everything else is peripheral. Constitution is no exception, and therefore neither are the Leading Principles, nor Augsburg Seminary either—which, moreover, ought to be superfluous to say.

The great question does not become: Does one stand in harmony with this or that group of principles, this or that wing of an aristocracy of office, this or that institution? But the question—the real one—becomes: Does one stand in accord with the future of God's kingdom, and is one willing to let oneself be used for the kingdom's advance, to labor for the fulfillment of the prayer: hallowed be your name; your kingdom come; as in heaven so also on earth—your will be done!

(Conclusion.)